

**THE
MORNING
OF
SPIRITUAL
YOUTH
IMPROVED,
IN THE PROSPECT OF
Old Age and its Infirmities**

by

John Church

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*** START OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK THE MORNING
OF SPIRITUAL YOUTH IMPROVED, IN THE PROSPECT OF OLD
AGE AND ITS INFIRMITIES ***

Transcribed from the [1814] R. Thomas edition by David Price, email
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**THE
MORNING
OF
SPIRITUAL YOUTH
IMPROVED,
IN THE PROSPECT OF
Old Age and its Infirmities;**

BEING A
LITERAL AND SPIRITUAL PARAPHRASE

On the Twelfth Chapter of Ecclesiastes.

In a Series of Letters.

By J. CHURCH, V. D. M.

“Rejoice, O young Man, in thy Youth.”—*Solomon.*

“The prudent Man foreseeeth the Evil, and hideth himself.”

“—and add to your Faith Virtue.”—*Peter.*

LONDON:

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PREFACE.

CHRISTIAN READER,

I need make no apology for publishing the following Letters, as the Subject was first delivered in several Discourses, and is now by the particular desire of many friends, published to the Church in the form of familiar Letters—appearing in the homely dress of plain speech, they will, doubtless, meet the censure of the carnal critic, but my mind is fully made up on that point—that which is highly esteemed amongst such men, is abominable in the sight of God.

Being favored with much of the presence of God in preaching the Sermons, and since then in writing some of these Letters, I trust every wise, spiritual, and humble Christian, into whose hands this Work may fall, will be edified, reprov'd, comforted, and built up on their most holy Faith.—

*So prays thy witting Servant
in Christ Jesus,*

A handwritten signature in black ink on a yellow rectangular background. The signature reads "J. Church." in a cursive script.

LETTER I.

TO AMICUS.

Lambeth, 1814.

DEAR FRIEND,

HAVING waded through many deep waters of late, and, I hope, learned many interesting lessons in the School of the Cross, I cannot forbear dropping you a few thoughts on the great things of God. It is my mercy and yours, that our salvation is the joint work of the adorable Trinity in Unity, originating in eternal love, planned in infinite wisdom, and executed by almighty power. This salvation I have been led to prize, of late, more than ever I did; and to bless a covenant God that I ever heard its joyful sound; that I was ever convinced of my need of its blessings; that I ever was enabled to receive it as my own: which glorious salvation consists in the pardon of sin—the acceptance of the Saviour’s obedience—the clear witness of God’s Spirit—and the happy heart-felt communion with God. This is the salvation of the Gospel I have been made acquainted with in some degree, and trust I shall yet more abundantly, even in this present life, and beyond the grave be favored with it in body and soul for ever. This is what I have in humble hope and expedition, and God declares it shall not be cut off. The Spirit of God is given us as an earnest of this, and faith is the evidence of it—and though I am not yet in the enjoyment of it, the promise still stands firm, *Thine eyes shall see the king in his beauty—they shall behold the land that is far off. Thine eyes:* are you inclined to ask, Whose eyes?—the answer is ready—those who are in possession of a good work of grace—hence, *having begun the good work, he will perform it unto the day of Jesus Christ.*—Sometimes you hope, you believe, you trust, nay you are sure this work is begun; then I am sure it will be carried on, and must be completed; for the Man will not be in rest till the great work is done, and he presents us to

himself a glorious Church, not having spot or wrinkle, nor any such thing. May you and I live in the pleasing prospect of this, and finally, die to enjoy it—no doubt it will be an heaven worth dying for—when I contemplate this glory, I forget the trials of the way.

But, perhaps, my dear friend, while reading this, is particularly tried *in the way; for as vinegar upon nitre, so is he that singeth songs to an heavy heart*. Well, then, I must pay you a visit in Achor's vale, where I know you are truly safe, though miserable; reflecting on the days that are past, and contrasting them with what you now feel and fear—once feeling light, joy, peace, comfort, love, zeal, activity, and diligence; but now you feel darkness, insensibility, lowness the workings of inbred sin, and too often have to lament the out-breakings of them. This may be succeeded by legal bondage, unbelief, fretfulness, enmity, and a sad distance between God and the soul; and instead of activity and diligence, a general stupor; calling all in question, because you cannot act as you have formerly done—quite forgetting him that has said, and who is now making good his promise, *Even the youths shall faint and be weary, and the young men shall utterly fail, but those who wait on the Lord shall renew their strength*.

Permit me, my brother, just to intimate, that there is nothing singular in your trials; it appears to be the very path the Redeemer went, and the very footsteps of the flock. Hence we read, directly after the Baptism of our dear Lord, when his soul was filled with all the fulness of God; when the Father, with an audible voice, proclaimed from above, *This is my beloved Son!*—and the Holy Spirit was seen hovering over his head, in a body of light, just like a Dove in its descent—the Redeemer rising from the watery tomb, and the gazing spectators astonished at the solemn scene—immediately after this transaction we find him led into the Wilderness to be tempted of the Devil; and he was with the wild beasts, and evil angels came to him; and upon the back of this, Satan, the head, the chief Devil, most daringly tempted him to presumption, to doubt his Sonship, and to commit suicide!—and can my brother wonder that he is a subject of temptation—*that* he has forty days of mourning, without a spiritual entertainment, or the manifestative presence of Christ—*that* he is among the wild beasts of his inbred sins—that evil thoughts stirred up by evil angels, should ever trouble or visit him? And can you wonder that you should be tempted to doubt your sonship—tempted to presume—that is, forbear to use the scripture

means in time of trouble, or even tempted to suicide? You think some strange thing has happened to you, but this is the path the Redeemer trod, in his measure—and, recollect, the servant is not greater than his Lord—it is enough to be as he was, that we may be as he *is*. This part of your experience was strikingly exhibited in the case of the Israelites, who came through the Red Sea with joy and praise—shouted victory, through the mercy of Jehovah—and felt happy that they were delivered. But their felicity was soon abated, for they were ordered to encamp at Marah, in the Wilderness. So you find it: you have been convinced of your lost state; you have felt the slavery of sin and the Devil; you have felt the bondage of the Law; you have seen the Redeemer making an atonement for sinners: your faith has received this; your hope has enjoyed this; your love has been led out to him in sweet return; and though you still felt yourself a sinner, yet your mind was happy in Jesus, his glorious Person, and his great Work. Here you sung with Moses and Miriam, with gospel ministers and people, *The Lord is my strength and my song, he also is become my salvation, and I will exalt him*. But your note was soon changed, for you presently found yourself in the wilderness of fears, lest you had been deluded, and lest you had presumed—lest your grief had been like Esau's, and your joys the raptures of a way-side hearer; quite forgetting that that religion which comes from God, always leads to God, as our salvation and our eternal all. This was certainly your experience; then why doubt the reality of it? The commandment has gone forth, that you, for wise and God-glorifying purposes, should pitch your tent at Marah; here you must taste of the bitter cup of sorrow. This will only endear the Tree of Life to you, who was cut down, and cast into deeper waters than you can possibly go into; and will lead your faith to apprehend, that though your waters are deep and bitter, yet faith tastes them sweet, by virtue of Christ's removing the curse—

Thus believing we rejoice,
To see the curse removed.

Your path may indeed be hard and thorny, but, bless God, there is no curse in it; let this console your mind, I am sure it will, if the Holy Spirit gives you power to believe it. Your present experience of darkness, guilt, deadness, bondage, contraction of spirit, and great stupor, are the days of evil that Solomon speaks of, which are many, but must at last issue in an

exceeding and an eternal weight of glory. But seeing such are the days that must come on the followers of the dear Saviour, how truly important, and how highly interesting that exhortation in the twelfth of Ecclesiastes, *Remember now thy Creator, in the days of thy youth, while the evil days come not, and the years draw nigh, wherein thou shalt say I have no pleasure in them.* Solomon could well talk of these things, for he had a wonderful share of them, and wrote the whole Book of Ecclesiastes upon the subject. The word is said by some, to mean the Preacher, but others think it signifies Restoration to the Church. It was also written by him in his old age, after his recovery from backsliding; as such it must be a precious treasure in the hands of a poor sinner, who knows the plague of his heart, the weakness of human nature, the inconstancy and mutability of all transitory things, of all terrestrial objects.

This book shews the vanity of all things out of Christ; that they are fleeting, insubstantial, and disappointing; that they elude the grasp of their followers, and leave the soul in darkness, misery, and woe. Having learnt so much by deep heart-felt experience, of the power of grace and the power of sin, and having been deeply taught by the Holy Ghost, he advises as a father to his children, how to act, before the sad days of tribulation come on; and this is agreeable to his own declaration, *The prudent man foreseeth the evil (i.e.) day and hideth himself, but the simple pass on and are punished.* Thus in this chapter he exhorts, which, through God's assistance, I shall consider in an experimental manner; and shew, I hope, the mind of the Spirit upon this important theme.

I have often been grieved when this precious text has been taken by mere Moralists, who knew nothing of the Spirit's work upon the heart, as the testifier of Jesus; and applied to youth, literally, who are destitute of the grace of God—and by a mere moral harangue, they have set youth to perform a task they themselves never did. Hence, in general, Sermons are preached to young people from this passage, when the very passage shews they are characters that have been taught of God; else why exhort to a remembrance of that glorious object, Thy Creator? it must imply some knowledge of him; and this great Creator can only be known by his own Word and Spirit; only seen in his own light, *for the world by wisdom knows not God*, nor can all the works of God lead us to God, as some dream; there is no coming to a knowledge of trusting in, or loving, or obeying God, but

by the glorious Mediator, and the impulse of the Holy Ghost. I consider it necessary then, my dear Brother, to shew you, *First*, The Characters addressed in this important exhortation—the *Youth*. *Secondly*, the grand object recommended to their attention, *Thy Creators*. *Thirdly*, What is implied in the idea of *remembering him*. *Fourthly*, The *Arguments* the wise man makes use of to urge this important act, viz. *The approach of evil days and years*—which I shall endeavor to explain in a scriptural and experimental way, to comfort some poor mourner; to show the value of a precious Saviour; and endear salvation, by free grace alone.

On the first head of this subject, I would just observe, the blessedness of being early called by the grace of God, can never be fully appreciated in this world. We read of some who were called at a very early period: Jeremiah was really sanctified from the womb: John the Baptist was filled with the Holy Ghost in the womb; which shews the possibility of a work of grace in the souls of those who die in infancy, as they are in general, if not *all*, influenced by the Holy Spirit before their departure, and are passively the subjects of Regeneration. What a consolation for a parent bereaved of a *lovely babe*!—It appears Joseph was early taught of God; perhaps the first martyr, Abel, was—it is very clear Obadiah, Josiah, David, and Solomon, were early converted. Samuel and Timothy knew the Saviour at a very early period—the Lord was their guide from their youth. This saves a person from many a bitter pang,—many a sigh, many a tear, many a deep, black, sad reflection of parents, broken hearts, violated sabbaths, a despised gospel, a ruined pocket, and constitution. To be sure grace shines very bright in the calling of such; but you and I must say, we are greater debtors to preserving grace. I rejoice your mind was so early imprest with the power of godliness, and that you was directed under a sound ministry, which clearly pointed out the way of salvation, by free grace alone; for the labour of some foolish preachers wearieth every one, because they know not how to go to the city. But this is not the youth in the text, they are the seed which the Lord hath blessed—the seed of God; the seed that was to serve the Lord, called the seed of Jacob; for these the Redeemer entered into a covenant with his Father—for these he travailed in spirit, groaned, cried, obeyed, bled, and died. Hence the promise, *He shall see of the travail of his soul and be satisfied*. This is begun in our conversion, and will be accomplished in our final glorification. Hence the Psalmist says, As

arrows in the hand of the mighty so are the children of thy youth. And the matter of the covenant between the Father and the Son, is thus exhibited—*Thy people shall be willing in the day of thy power, in the beauties of holiness. From the womb of the morning thou hast the dew of thy youth—* which beautiful passage Mr. Hervey translates, and paraphrases thus: “As the morning is the mother of dews; produces them, as it were, from a prolific womb; and scatters them with the most lavish abundance, over all the surface of the earth: *So shall thy seed be,* O thou everlasting Father! By the preaching of thy word, shall such an innumerable race of regenerate children be born to thee, and fill all lands. Millions, millions of willing converts, shall *croud* into thy family, and *replenish* thy church; till they become like the stars of Heaven, or the sands of the sea, for multitude; or even as *numberless*, as these fine *spangles*, which now cover the face of nature.”

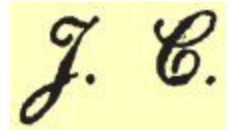
Of the same opinion was the late Mr. Huntington; see his “Light shining in Darkness;” on the 110th *Psalms*. “The youth which is to spring from the womb and is to be numerous as the drops of the dew, seem to *be* a time yet to come; when the knowledge of the Lord shall cover the earth—when a nation shall be born at once—when a little one shall become a thousand—and when the Lord’s family will consist of strong men in the faith; who are called youth; instead of thy fathers, shall be thy children, whom thou mayest make Princes in the earth;” this must be when the greatest kingdom under the whole heavens shall be given to the saints of the most high, and they shall take it, and possess it, for

Jesus shall reign where’er the Sun
Does his successive journies run.

The truly excellent Dr. Hawker reads this passage in reference to the heavenly extraction of the Lord’s people, to shew, That sovereign grace will give to Christ an abundance of souls, like the dew drops; so numerous as to be perfectly incalculable: “And they shall come of heavenly extraction, as the dew from God, *being born not of the will of the flesh, but of God;* and unperceived, unnoticed, and unknown, as the silent drops of the morn; *for the kingdom of God cometh not by observation:* and as they are begotten like the dew, without the aid of man, so also shall they be preserved by the same predisposing cause, without man’s descent.—*Not by might or by*

power, but by my spirit, saith the Lord of Hosts.” Thus the youth to whom Solomon writes are the spiritual seed of God, and not to mere carnal worldly youth, who are destitute of the knowledge of God. Dear *Amicus*, adieu—Grace and peace be with you.

I remain, your's in the Sinner's friend,

A handwritten signature in black ink on a yellow rectangular background. The signature consists of the letters 'J.' followed by 'C.' in a cursive, calligraphic style.

LETTER II.

TO AMICUS.

Lambeth, 1814.

BELOVED FRIEND,

AMIDST a vast multitude of thoughts which occurred to my mind this morning, one more than all the rest, seemed longest to abide, namely, that as the Lord's people are called Servants as well as Sons, it appears to me that the services of none are accepted of God, but only the services of those who are Sons by adoption and graces and by the testimony of the Holy Spirit in the heart. Such Sons are also called his Servants, who shall serve him: they were by nature the servants of the Devil, wore his livery, and did his will; but Almighty grace having wrought a glorious change in the heart, there is a change of the service; and this service is not in the oldness of the letter, but in the newness of the spirit; then it must be with a new heart, a new spirit; with new views, aims, pursuits and ends. Into this service we are first pressed—then we become volunteers, and though we meet with many discouragements by the way, yet we are not tired of our Master, nor he of us; nor do we serve in heart, in affection, in word and deed, as we wish we could, yet he kindly accepts the will for the deed, and says, *If there be a willing mind, it is accepted according to what a man hath, and not according to what he hath not.* In the service of so divine a Lord, our chariot wheels would fain run swift along. My dear Brother can recollect when his feet run cheerfully in the way—*ye did run well, who did hinder you?* and you had a divine command for it—*Rejoice, O young man, in thy youth, and let thy heart cheer thee in the days of thy youth.* Walk in the way of thy new heart, and in the light of truth that you are favored with; but it is added, that all this work must be tried, judged, and proved, that it may appear to be genuine, that what belongs to God may go to God, and what

belongs to nature you may discover, and lament; for this is the design of the furnace, the design of the fire of tribulation—therefore do not be alarmed, as though some unaccountable thing had happened. In the days of prosperity you did right to be joyful; in those days of adversity you must now consider, the Lord approved of the days of your youth, and even promises a renewal of them; and David declared he experienced it: this you may see in the following texts—*I remember thee, and the kindness of thy youth, and the love of thy espousals, when thou wentest after me in a land that was not sown.—He shall return to the days of his youth. Thy youth is renewed as the Eagle's.* This is experienced after a season of backsliding and darkness, deadness, and misery. In these youthful days it is necessary to be diligent, as dark days may come. Hence the exhortation, *Remember thy Creator in the days of thy youth.* These youthful days do not so much regard the time of life as the time of the light, love, and liberty of the children of God; these are our first, best, and sweetest days.

Hence it is said, *it is good for a man that he bear the yoke in his youth:* whatever may be the sense of this text, it is a point beyond all controversy, that it is a mercy to be taught out of the Law, in our first setting out, to bear the yoke of our transgressions, and receive deliverance from them by the precious blood and righteousness of Christ. It is likewise a mercy to be in the service of Christ, in health and strength of body and mind; the service of Christ is easy and his burden light; so he told his disciples, *Take my yoke upon you.* The word youth, does not always signify the term of years; this is evident from Job's pathetic moan—*O that it was with me as in the days of my youth,* when I was blest with health of body, peace of mind, cheerful days, plenty of ordinances, and means to get the knowledge Jesus; and an inclination thereto, while the Spirit taught me to say, *My Father, thou art the guide of my youth.* And hence the apostate and backslider is said, to forsake the guide of her youth. Thus it appears the time to remember our creators is the days when first imprest with the good things of God; when powerfully drawn on by the cords of love; when we feel strong, lively, warm, and affectionate; when peace, comfort, and joy, are felt; when the mind is free from care, vexation, temptation, and misery; when God blesses us with health and strength, with ministers and books, with ordinances, and the company of saints. These are our most happy but not most god-glorifying times; yet, while they last, Solomon advises a careful attention to

great truths, as we may meet with many crafty, cruel, malicious enemies to God, enemies to the doctrines of the Trinity in Unity; enemies to the Covenant of Redemption; enemies to free Grace, to the Work of the Holy Ghost; to the Divinity and work of the adorable Immanuel; and in fact, to every revealed truth. So Paul advises, *Put on the whole armour of God, that ye may stand in the evil day*. Every part of this armour will be needed, for it is provided for poor believers, who have to wrestle hard with sins, and doubts, and fears, nothing short of an experimental knowledge of the truth will abide the furnace, will stand in the days of evil, which are coming on, and which all the Lord's children, either in a greater or less degree, must endure for it is plain those who fall away had only the form of godliness, without the power: there may be a form of sound words, a form of knowledge; a form of faith, of hope of love, of humility—this is but superficial; my dear Brother, I hope, has been convinced of the danger of this, and that nothing short of the gracious teachings of the Holy Ghost can satisfy his mind. This leads me to consider the second particular I promised to attend to in my first letter—The glorious object—*Thy Creators*.

I need not tell you I am no scholar, I wish I was; but the passage must be read in the plural, according to the testimony of most Hebrew scholars—*Remember now thy CREATORS*. There are other texts which must be read in the same way: *Where is God thy MAKERS, who giveth songs in the night? Let Israel rejoice in THEM that made him. Thy MAKERS is thy husband; the Lord of Hosts is his name*. We live in an awful day, wherein the most crying sin of our nation is the dreadful opposition to the doctrine of the most adorable Trinity in Unity, though it is a truth so clearly revealed—the foundation of the Church and the christian's highest glory. Alas! how awfully opposed! Many great and learned, experimental christians have employed their pens in proving from sacred scripture, this most glorious point of Doctrine, the foundation of all the rest. The adversaries of this truth pretend to hold the Unity of the Godhead—so do we. They say there is but one God—so do we; but can they prove that the Godhead does not, cannot admit of *three* distinct Persons in that Essence?—No! We, then, who are Trinitarians, can prove that there is but one simple, undivided Essence; and, that, if there is any truth in the Bible, there are *distinct subsistences* in that one Godhead—that these three are equal in power, majesty, dignity, and glory; co-equal, co-essential, and co-eternal. There are

not three Gods, but *three Persons* in the Godhead. That there are three distinct Subsistences, which, for want of better words, we call *Persons*, is evident from a vast many passages of scripture—distinct from each other, in Person, Name, and Office; for, to what beside the term Person, can we with any propriety apply the distinct acts of speaking, working, and commanding? And the Persons in the Trinity are clearly set forth by their personal characters, such as *I, me, him, thou, his, he*. The scriptures plainly declare that *there are three that bear record in heaven, the Father, the Word, and the Holy Ghost—and these three are one*—one in the divine Essence, undivided, which Essence is peculiar to the three; yet these have different modes of subsisting in this Essence, which we must call Persons—and they must be Persons, to be Testifiers—testifying is a personal act; if the Father is one testifier, the Son another, and the Holy Ghost a third, they must be three *Persons*, not three Gods; only one in the divine Essence, but three distinct in Personality, Name, and Office. The Unity of the Godhead is exprest in this text, *Hear O Israel, the Lord our God is one Lord*. But the Plurality of Persons in the Godhead is exprest as before—*There are three which bear record, the Father, the Word, and the Holy Ghost*. There is one God; this is not said to the exclusion of the Son and the Spirit, for the Word is applied to both as well as to the Father, and in the same senses.

This doctrine will still appear more plain, to my dear brother, by the *plural* names of God. In the first verse of the Bible it is evident—*In the beginning God created the heaven and the earth*. That this name is *plural*, is plain by the work of the distinct Persons. *And the spirit of God moved upon the face of the waters*. And the third person is spoken of as the WORD, who said *Let there be light*. Thus the *three in one* were concerned in creation. In Ephesians iii, 9, God is said to create all things by Jesus Christ—this is one Person—Christ is said to be creator too—*by the word of the Lord was the heavens made, and all the host of them by the breath of his mouth*. Here is the Word that was with God, and was God; and the spirit of God moved upon the face of the waters. *By his spirit he garnished the heavens, and his hand framed the crooked Serpent*. This is the Holy Trinity in Unity—the Persons who said, *Let us make man in OUR image, after OUR likeness*. *Behold the man is become at one of us. Go to, let us go down.—Whom shall I send, and who will go for us?* These words clearly prove a plurality

of Persons. *If any man love me, my Father will love him, and WE will come unto him, and make OUR abode with him.*

In the Epistle of John we read of Communion with the Father, and the Son; and Paul speaks of Communion with the Holy Ghost. The glorious Covenant of Grace shews a Plurality of Persons. Divine worship is to be given to the three Persons. Baptism is in their Names: sometimes one Person is mentioned before the other; *the grace of our Lord Jesus Christ, the love of God, and the communion of the Holy Ghost*; here Christ is first mentioned. *The Lord direct your hearts into the love of God, and into a patient waiting for Christ. The acknowledgement of God, and of the Father, and of Christ*—thus we see the Spirit is mentioned first. In the first chapter of Ephesians the Father is first introduced—Paul prays that the *Father of our Lord Jesus Christ would grant the spirit of wisdom in the knowledge of Christ*. These, and many other passages evidently prove that there are *Three in One* and *One in Three*, God blessed for evermore; so the Scripture teaches, and so must we believe; to err in this subject is fatal. But the Spirit has engaged to lead us into all truth, nor can one humble follower of Jesus go down to the shades of death, opposing this glorious doctrine. How these are *one*, and how each Person subsists in the one Divine Essence, is not for us to know, nor is it of any importance, it is enough for me to know, that the terms of Father, Son, and Spirit, are not given to shew what the Trinity is in the divine Essence, as God; but what they are to the church in an everlasting Covenant; and this is life eternal to know the Father, that adopted me as his own—to know the Lord Jesus, in the greatness of his salvation, by the teaching and leading of the Holy Ghost. This is the harmonious witness in the word, and I bless God for the same in the heart. There are three which bear witness; and he that believeth on the Son hath the witness in himself; and this is the witness, the Father says, *Yea I have loved thee*; the Redeemer says, *I have redeemed thee*; and the voice of the Spirit is known, *I have called thee*. This is the point I want you, my brother, to apprehend, to feel, and enjoy. This is a religion that will stand the test, will bear the furnace, and all religion, besides what comes from, and leads to the adorable Trinity, is madness, delusion and daring presumption! This is the *maker* or MAKERS—CREATORS, *father, husband, friend, and God*.

The wise man not only points out the glorious Object, but the Work in which they are engaged, even the Work of Creation. These glorious Persons having formed the grand plan of salvation, which was the first great act of Jehovah, in Council and Covenant, now brings forth the grand theatre of the Universe, whereon to display the glories of rich, free, restoring grace; and this act of power, love, wisdom, and goodness, is the joint Work of the *three Persons*; as the word *God* is a plural term, *Elohim*, or as some term it *Alehim*—the Persons engaged, the Covenanters. This is a point that has been long proved by good and great men—the several acts of Creation—God created the heaven and earth, formed both; then the Spirit's, act—and *the Spirit of God*, the Lord and giver of life, *moved upon the face of the waters*, to separate the parts which were mixed together, and to give them a quickening virtue, to produce living creatures in them. Then the Saviour is represented as saying, *Let there be light, and there was light*. This came from himself, who is called the Light of the World. *And God said* (this is repeated nine times over; and as the term God is plural, and includes the Three, there is great propriety and beauty in the expression) *Let us make man in OUR image, after OUR likeness*. This consultation is designed to point out that honor and dignity that was to be conferred on Man, the noblest work of all his creatures—in *his image*, as God's vicegerent; having dominion over the creatures; erect in his body; with every excellent endowment of his mind; in purity, holiness, and righteousness; in wisdom and beauty—thus man was made in his image. But though this is a great truth, yet I humbly conceive this is not all; from all eternity God had a favour towards man; and having exalted the dear Saviour to be the great Head of the Church, he set him up in the nature of his people, so that Adam was formed in the nature, in the very image which God had designed to honour Christ in; that image made he man: this was agreeable to divine consultation. In this image our dear Lord four thousand years afterwards made his appearance; and this was the joint work of the Holy Trinity—a *body hast thou prepared me*. He took part of the children's flesh and blood—*The power of the Holy Ghost shall come on thee, and that which shall be born unto thee shall be called the Child of the Most High*.

Thus the formation of our nature is the joint work of the Trinity, in the first and second Adam; but this point will appear of equal importance if we contemplate our New Creation, as the work of the same divine Persons.

Our Regeneration is called a Creation, but more of this in my next. The best of blessings attend you.

So prays your willing servant to command
in all Godliness,

A handwritten signature in black ink on a yellow rectangular background. The signature consists of the letters 'J.' followed by 'C.', both in a cursive script.

LETTER III.

TO AMICUS.

DEAR FRIEND,

GRACE and peace be with you. I thought it needful to drop you another Letter on a subject of infinite importance to you, to myself and to the whole church of God. The Saviour, in a conversation with a learned and polite Doctor of Divinity, positively declared the necessity of another, a New, a second *Birth*. Blessed be God, the salvation of the children of God is completed without this, but we must be born again to know this salvation is ours; and to pretend to lay claim to such Salvation, without being born again, is most daring presumption! This *new Birth* is a change of heart and life; the formation of a new man; an infusion of holy principles—all new—every thing; that is, every principle which the Holy Spirit inspires is new; new views, new sensations, new ideas, new pursuits; and new trials; all is become new. *If any man be in Christ Jesus he is become new*. This birth goes by various names in scripture—it is stiled *a Calling*; *The master is come and calleth for thee*. It is represented as an *implanting* or *engrafting*—*Cut off from the old stock*: Our souls cleave to Jesus as our all in all. It is a *Conquest*; by the power of the Holy Spirit our enmity is slain, our wills subdued, and our affections set on heavenly objects. It is called an *heavenly Birth*—Of the seed of God's word we are said to be begotten to a lively hope. A new man is formed; for this the Redeemer travailed in spirit; for this ministers labour and toil; and to enjoy God in Christ Jesus, no small portion of spiritual labour falls to the share of the happy possessor. The Saviour enters the soul; this must create a stir there. He comes into, and by the door of the heart; all that come in any other way, as sin and Satan did, are thieves and robbers. Upon his entrance we, by his light, see our lost state—feel our guilt—conscience is quickened, as well as the mind enlightened; and here, my brother, you may discover the vast disparity

between the Possessor and the mere nominal Professor; it is not to be seen either in their light, or conduct, for a man destitute of the grace of God, may be clear in his head, and upright in his moral deportment. This is the snare that is come upon the Churches: these are the false evidences by which thousands are deceived—it is not enough, the main spring is wanting, which is LIFE. This is the genuine work of God: this proves our union with the Living Vine. By this life I feel myself condemned by the Law. I feel a spirit of bondage to fear. I feel the sting of death. I feel the workings of corruption, which I knew nothing of before. I feel dreadful apprehensions of God's wrath; and while my conscience feels these things, I see, in the light of the word, and by the Spirit, the exact suitableness of the dear Saviour. I am enabled by the same Spirit to believe he lived, obeyed, suffered, died, and is risen again, and receives poor sinners—the lost, the helpless, the guilty, and the vile. This begets a hope in my mind that he will save me. The Promises encourage me—the freeness of grace—the Lord delighting in mercy, through the satisfaction of Jesus—the scriptural account of poor sinners as vile as me being saved. These things encourage me to hope; while my faith, small as it is, argues at times, as Manoah's wife did, If the Lord had meant to have destroyed me, would he have shewed me what I see?—or told me what he has? No, no!

But while I thank God, and am taking courage, perhaps sin again overcomes me—the Law still works wrath; Satan then takes the advantage, and down I sink again, and must there lay till the dear Father of Mercies draw me to Christ again. Thus the spiritual life, at this time, hangs in doubt, and there is no assurance of life, either spiritual or eternal. This is travelling in spirit, coming to the birth, and no strength to bring forth. This is tarrying long in the place of the breaking forth of children; panting, breathing, looking, thirsting, longing for the knowledge of the pardon of sin, the clear witness of the Spirit, and the sweet, smiting, kind, loving approbation of God. Such souls are already pronounced blessed, and what God has promised he will surely perform. Such long to come forth; are afraid of peace and comfort, ease and quietness, lest it should not be God's work; and such would rather be always in bondage than in carnal ease, or false peace or confidence.

Beautiful that Promise, *Blessed are they that hunger and thirst after righteousness, for they shall be filled.* Such are represented as waiting upon

God. Those that wait upon the Lord shall renew their strength—and they shall not be ashamed that wait for me. At the Pool of Bethesda they lay till Jesus appears—at the posts of God's Doors they wait till favour is shewed them—they are admitted to the Inner Court, till faith gathers strength enough to believe in the love of God towards them; and till they can receive into their souls the Atonement this gives peace to the conscience, and joy in God, and this honor have all the saints. This is the New Birth, which you, I trust, know something of experimentally; but darkness will sometimes hide it from you. I must recommend you a sweet text in Job. *Thine age shall be clearer than the noon day—thou shalt shine forth, thou shalt be clear as the morning.*

But this new-making second Birth, and new Creation, is the joint work of the adorable Trinity, and is, of course, property ascribed to each Person, *Remember therefore thy new Creators.* Let Israel rejoice in *them* that made him. God the Father is called the Father of Christ, the Father of Lights. Of his own will begat he us, with the Word of Truth. He sheds the dew of the Spirit upon us abundantly, through Jesus Christ our Lord. This Work is also attributed to Jesus; he is the Resurrection and the Life—he raiseth up and quickeneth whom he will; and it is by virtue of his Resurrection from the dead that we are begotten again to a lively hope.

The blessed and eternal Spirit, the Lord and giver of Life, is also the Author of this New Creation—*Except a man be born of water and the Spirit he cannot enter into the kingdom of heaven.* It is the Spirit that quickens; he it is prepares the mind for Christ, then testifies of Christ to the soul. May you, my dear Friend, enjoy much of his testimony, and set to your seal, that *God is true*—and, if I have not tired your patience, let me remind you of another great act of your CREATORS, the completing the Work in a manifestative way, in the glorious Resurrection of the Body, to enjoy endless felicity with the soul. This is what we have in lively hope and earnest expectation; for this we groan—this is the redemption of the purchased Possession. God our covenant Father loved our bodies as well as our souls—the dear Redeemer bought the one as well as the other—he suffered in the body for sins done by the body. The Holy Spirit graciously takes up his abode in the soul, as the earnest of the future inheritance.

This Doctrine has been denied by many—this has been ridiculed as contrary to sense and reason; but why should it be thought a thing incredible *that God should raise the Dead*? it can easily be accomplished by the infinite power and wisdom of God, as well as the first formation of it; the one will be as easy to him as the other—the sacred scriptures assure us of it, our faith gives credit to it; and this faith is not in vain, the Redeemer would lose a part of his purchase if the dead rise not; besides, he has redeemed them to God, and from the grave; and the general judgment requires that those who sleep in the dust should come forth. There is a necessity of the body rising, else we should lose part of our bliss; for we shall want some of our members in heaven, as the eye, to see Christ in the flesh, and one another; and the ear, to hear the everlasting songs of praise; and the tongue, to sing them.—Nor is this contrary to reason; hence the dear Redeemer, and his servant Paul, has set it forth by the figure of a corn of wheat, which, being sown, alters, corrupts, and then springs up a very different figure, yet it is the same corn of wheat that was sown, though now it appears with a stalk, a blade, and an ear: so our bodies will be sown; and spring up again with additional circumstances. Blessed and holy is he that hath part in the first Resurrection. What heart can conceive the joyful meeting of soul and body again? This is most affectingly described by Blair:

—Nor shall the conscious soul
Mistake its partner, but amidst the crowd,
Singling its other half, into its arms
Shall rush, with all the impatience of a man
That's new come home, and having long been absent,
With haste runs over every different room,
In pain to see the whole. Thrice happy meeting!
Nor time, nor death shall ever part them more.

This Resurrection to eternal life, is the joint work of our glorious *Makers*.—*Knowing that he which raised up Jesus from the dead, shall raise us up also by him, and shall present us with you.* So this great act is ascribed to the dear Saviour; he shall change our vile bodies. The Holy Spirit will have an hand in this momentous affair, he shall also quicken our mortal bodies. And it is a charming thought, my Brother, that as sure as we have been quickened in the soul we shall be in the body—certain as we hear the voice

of Jesus in the Gospel, we shall hear it in the Resurrection, calling us forth to eternal life. And as sure as the Gospel trumpet proclaims liberty to our souls, the last trumpets sound shall bring liberty to our bodies. Let this thought comfort you, nor shall you be ashamed of your hope, for the mouth of the Lord hath spoken it.

It is time I proceed to speak of the third particular, the Wise Man's exhortation—*Remember*.—We meet with many such fatherly admonitions in scripture, and in fact, God promises we shall remember. *Thou shalt remember all the way the Lord thy God hath led thee in the Wilderness*.—And one of the blessed Offices of the Holy Ghost is that of a Remembrancer. This influence over the mind we often need in our state of pilgrimage: we have, naturally, bad memories—besides, Satan is a thief, and he is secretly watching to steal all the good he can from us, and to leave us all the dregs. Our inbred sins, and many outward foes, also hurt our memories—they are Foxes that spoil the Vines, that have tender grapes. It is an unspeakable mercy that our Salvation does not depend upon our memories, but in God's remembering of us. Hence he has said, *If I forget thee, O Jerusalem, let my tongue cleave to the roof of my mouth*. He remembered his Covenant, he remembered his mercy. *I will remember my Covenant with thee*. Then he appeals to parental affections, and asks, *Can a woman forget her sucking child? Yea, she may forget, (perhaps, my Brother, I am an instance of it) yet will I not forget thee. My kindness shall not depart from thee, nor the Covenant of my peace be removed, saith the Lord, that hath mercy on THEE, O thou afflicted, tossed with tempest, and not comforted*.—Here is our security, though we are so forgetful, so ungrateful—forever we dwell in his heart, forever in his mind; and he has graciously intimated there are some things which he can never do, consistently with his Nature, his Perfections, and Covenant. It was impossible for God to lie: he cannot forget his people, he will not remember their sins; he will never leave nor forsake those he once has loved.

But we are exhorted to *Remember him*. This act, in scripture, signifies to keep in mind somewhat future and important, that we may notice it when it comes again. *Remember thou keep holy the Sabbath day*: it signifies to think of, and deeply consider. *When I remember thee on my bed and meditate on thee in the night watches*: it signifies to love and esteem. *No man remembered that same poor man*: to praise or mention the great acts of

covenant love, in a way of gratitude. *Remember his marvellous works which he hath done*: it signifies to call to mind. *Remember that ye were Gentiles in the flesh*: so that we remember God, when we think of, believe in, and depend on him for help and strength. *Some put their trust in horses, some in chariots, but we will remember the Lord our God*. To remember, in scripture, also signifies to make a collection. Hence the Apostle speaking of christian alms giving, says, *That we should remember the poor; the same which I was always forward to do*. Here, then, clearly appears our privilege, to think deeply of the great things of God—often to call them to mind; his everlasting love, its freeness and power; his everlasting covenant, that cannot be broken—his everlasting purposes to save the ruined, the helpless, and the vile. The everlasting righteousness of the dear God Man Mediator—the everlasting salvation with which all the elect shall be saved—the value, the efficacy, and unspeakable worth of the Atonement—the preciousness of the offices, glory, titles, and characters of the adorable Trinity in Unity. These things must be deeply learnt and kept in mind—the knowledge of them will surely do us good in the days of evil. To make a collection of the good things the Spirit has shewn to us—every token for good, every sermon he has blest with power, every sweet view of Jesus, every precious promise that has been applied, every ray of comfort, every season of access and nearness to God, every good word and kind hint he has given us, every deliverance he has wrought for us, every clear answer to prayer, whether of things temporal or spiritual. These we ought to notice, keep in mind, and often think over, with humility, with gratitude, with joy, with wonder; and ask, with the humble Ruth, *Why have I found grace in thy sight, that thou shouldest take knowledge of me, seeing I am but a stranger?*

Remember, with *diligence*; for as we abound in faith the Apostle says, We are to abound in all diligence. The pious Psalmist declares, His heart and spirit made a diligent search. The woman who had lost her piece of silver, is said, To sweep the house, and search diligently till she found it—and the Lord is sure to bless the diligent remembrance of himself; take the following texts: *The hand of the diligent maketh rich. The hand of the diligent shall bear rule. The substance of the diligent man is precious. The soul of the diligent shall be made fat. The thought of the diligent tends only to plenty. He that diligently seeketh good procureth favour.*—Thus we see what God has promised to the *diligent*. Say not this is *legal*, No!—I am

exhorting a believer, a quickened soul, one that has light, life, and love. All spiritual actions, acceptable to God, must spring from this quarter. Do you attend while you can to these important things, nor shall you fail of your reward. Be not deceived, God is not mocked, for whatever a man soweth that shall he also reap; and sure I am, every man shall find this text true in his experience, 2 Cor. ix, 6, *He that soweth sparingly shall reap sparingly: He which soweth bountifully shall reap bountifully.* So the scriptures affirm: I have found it and so shall you.

Thus while you are in health of body, peace of mind, furnished with the Spirit's influence as a Remembrancer—do call to mind, collect together and highly esteem these things, in meditation and prayer, and bless him for what he has done for you and in you. Turn down those pages in your Bible which you have found precious. Tell the dear people of God what Christ has done for you, that they may help you to praise him; for it is written, *They shall come and declare the Work of God in Zion.*—Nor would you lose any thing by it, should you keep a Diary of the Lord's dealings with you; it would be blessed to read it over another day, especially in the days of evil. Hence the exhortation, *Set thee up way marks: set thee up high heaps*—for, being like poor Jacob, we want reminding of our vows, and of God's goodness. Hence the command, *Arise, go to Bethel, where thou anointedst the Pillar, and make thee an altar to God, who appeared for thee when thou fleddest from the face of Esau.* It is well to remember what God has done for us, it encourages us in prayer and sweet confidence another day, as may be seen in this good man's History, Genesis xxxii, when pleading with God for his safety. He acknowledges past mercies, when he only possessed a staff twenty years before, and with it came over that very place where he then stood with two hands! He confesses his utter unworthiness, and pleads with God upon the ground of his promises he had applied to him in times past. Presents his prayer, mixed with thanksgiving, and obtains an answer. To feel gratitude is a mercy for it well becomes the just to be thankful.

I'll speak the honors of thy name,
With my last lab'ring breath;
And, speechless, clasp thee in my arms,
My joy in life and death.

This leads me to notice the reasons Why Solomon urges this point; *because the evil days and years are coming on, in which you will truly say, I have no pleasure in them.* And as you have a little pleasure at times, and have had a good deal of pleasure in the Bible, in the House of God, at the Table of the Lord, in company with the saints, in private retirement, in doing good to some, in pitying and in praying for others, and could understand something of this text, *They meetest him that rejoicest in thee—those that remember thee in thy ways.* In which things you have had pleasure, and could rejoice in these youthful days. But as some of these days are gone, and the rest may fly, let me advise you against such seasons as you will say, You have no pleasure in. But may the Lord water you every moment, and keep you night and day, to final salvation—maintain his own work, and bear testimony to your spirit, what is his work, and what is not. This you have prayed for many a time, and by terrible things in righteousness God is pleased often to answer us.

I remain your's,



LETTER IV.

TO AMICUS.

DEAR FRIEND,

I HAVE been a little concerned of late about the term *Prophet*. You guess what is the cause: many eminent professors, who are better acquainted with the News-paper than the Bible, have been lately venting out a good deal of spite against the memory of a late Minister, in consequence of what they call his ambitious and strongly-conceited *Epitaph*—“A Prophet hath been among them.” Quite forgetting that *all* real, faithful ministers, are entitled to the same name. The passage is, in part, quoted from Ezekiel ii, 5. *And they, whether they will hear, or whether they well forbear, for they are a rebellious house, yet shall know that a Prophet hath been among them.* I believe this name is applied to gospel ministers, nearly twenty times in the New Testament. Many things of eternal importance do they prophecy; and one branch of their prophecy I am sure you will find true, viz. That through much tribulation, they must enter the kingdom.—Jacob called his sons together and said, *I will tell you that which shall befall you in the latter days.* And Solomon, the type of our most blessed Immanuel, acting in this character, gives intimation, of what we must experience, that are created anew in Christ Jesus, and predestinated to the possession and enjoyment of the good work of Jesus—the good work of the eternal Spirit, and the good work and enjoyment of the blessed in Heaven. These God has ordained we should walk in—these are the evidences of union to Jesus; and as these are our privileges, so we must indeed drink of the same Cup Jesus did, and be immersed in the same Baptism. This was what the Holy Spirit witnessed to Paul, that in every city where he came bonds and affliction should await him, and he must go through them. No doubt these will have a glorious tendency, for our Covenant God does nothing in vain. You have hitherto been much indulged; I have really envied you, but the change you now

experience is only to shew you what need you have of the *whole* armour of God. You are but just come into the field of action, to combat with sin, Satan, errors, hypocrites, and erroneous men—to combat with many outward and inward foes, who now appear to your view.

But the dear Saviour will also appear very precious now, in other forms, to what you have ever felt of seen him. The Spirit will take every opportunity to reveal him just as you really need him. You will so learn Christ that you will be able to stand in these days of evil, which must come on the followers of the dear Saviour, and in which they must say they feel no pleasure. These evil days are set forth by Solomon under the following metaphors: The darkness of the sun, the moon, and stars, with a long, heavy, lowering sky. These things will be understood by the tried family of God; so that while you have the season of getting, or doing good, you must use that period for that use—hence such seasons are called an *Hour*—very short, but precisely fixed and determined by our covenant God. This season is called a *Day* that will soon go away, and the *Night* commence. This day is far spent with you, and a night is come on, in which you cannot work, but must wait—in which you cannot run, but must stand still, till the Lord sends you bright clouds, and a clear shining after rain. This season, in your experience, is called a *Morning*. How lovely and pleasant, while through the falling dew of God's favor, your graces budded, and the softly-pleasing southern gales caused your spikenard to send forth a delightful perfume. But evil days must come; not such evil days as must befall those as have no interest in, or love to the Saviour, and which may never come on in *this* world. Hence they are said to receive their good things in this life, but the righteous evil things. What a mercy, my brother! in all that befalls you there is no curse, no hatred in God to you, no unatoned guilt, no danger of hell, or of coming short of the desired haven; nor perhaps *many* fears or dread of *these* things: I hope they are gone out of your conscience long ago: not but you may be tempted about them for a time, but these shall be gone. Hence God promises, that on all hills which shall be digged with a mattock there shall not come thither the fears of briars and thorns; the real cause of these fears never shall come on you again. But the design of this Letter is simply to point out some of the evil days. Literally, Solomon refers to old age, with all the infinities that attend it. And this may be applied to the weakness of the human frame, the trouble, as well as to longevity of life;

and hence the 71st Psalm, composed by David, and indited by the Spirit, which belongs to Christ. He, the adorable Messiah, prays, *Cast me not off in the time of old age*, which is explained in the next clause, *when my strength faileth me*; and is doubtless the meaning of the 18th verse. This may be seen in his agony in the garden, when he cried out, *O my Father! if it be possible let this cup pass from me*. Now likewise his prayer was answered, for there appeared an angel from heaven to him to strengthen him. Thus age is not always applied to length of years; a person through affliction of body, many cares, crosses and losses, may be old; that is, as weak in constitution as the most aged and infirm character. No doubt many bear up amazingly well under the infirmities of age; but it must be allowed these are evil days: *that alone which can sweeten them, is a good hope through grace, the clear witness of the Spirit of God to the conscience, a lively precious faith in an everlasting covenant, in the blood of the Lamb, and in the faithfulness of that God who has graciously said, and even to old age and hoary hairs will I be with you*. Justified in the Redeemer's obedience, and kept firm in the truth. Solomon says, *The hoary head is a crown of glory if it be found in the way of righteousness*. Happy, thrice happy old man! just upon the threshold of that joy that awaits thee. Soon thy spiritual Joseph will send the waggon of his holy angels to conduct thee to himself, to behold all his glory.

Yet a season and you know,
Happy entrance shall be given—
All your sorrows left below,
And earth exchange'd for heaven.

What a prospect! what a scene! what a joy! nor shall you be disappointed of your hope, seeing Christ is commissioned to keep what you have long committed to his dear divine hands, your body and soul, the one for almost immediate glory, the other for a joyful resurrection.

Thus having viewed the passage in this literal form, let me return to point out some of the days of evil of which the Bible speaks, and you may meet with, that when they come you may remember I told you of them. When God is pleased to shew us our sinful hearts in that degree we are able to bear it. When conscience reproaches us for sins of omission and commission; sins long practised and long pursued by us. Satan taking the

advantage of these convictions, and throwing in his fiery darts. These are called the days of evil. *Wherefore should I fear in the days of evil, when the iniquity of my heels shall compass me about.* This is a time you will surely meet with, as Job and others have, who have said before you, *Thou makest me to possess the iniquities of my youth. Thou hast set my secret sins before me. Remember not the sins of my youth.* Such days as these, when guilt lies heavy on the conscience, you will feel no pleasure, till faith embraces the atonement, and banishes fear. Another evil day you will have is the day of temptation, when Satan is apparently let loose upon you, as he was upon poor Job, and Paul, and Jeremiah. When you will want your head covered in the day of battle, and feel your need of the shield of faith and the helmet of hope, the one to cover your head, the other to repel these fiery darts of the Devil, which he will shoot at you—fiery shot, from the burning malice of Hell, such as strong temptation to excite burning lusts, blasphemous thoughts of God, horrid suggestions, debasing thoughts of Christ, with all the Atheism, Deism, Arianism, Socinianism, Arminianism, and Antinomianism of the human heart, stirred up by the Devil, to foster despair, enmity, and hatred of God. Thus tried you must watch the motions of the Spirit, leading you to the death of the Saviour, and with your Spirit exclaiming, Thou, O Lord, art my hope in the day of evil.

I must notice another day: *Public troubles on the Church*, which I believe will come yet; I humbly conceive the man of sin will die hard; he seems to be hearing some of his dying groans at present, but it will have its last convulsive struggle; the hour of temptation must come on—the Church seems in her Laodicean state, and it may be really in that state for all I know, though many great men suppose the Church in her Sardian state; be that as it may, have we not cause to lament the general drowsiness of the Church, the very few names that have not defiled their garments—the cloudy state of Professor and Possessor—the state the Prophet alluded to, when he said, *It shall come to pass that the light shall not be clear nor dark.* Is it not true of that light which is in the Church? the people not wholly in the dark about the Doctrines of the Gospel, yet they are not clear; and perhaps, never was a time in the Church when God's real people were so cloudy, generally, about their interest in the Saviour, so that we may look for the sieve—a sifting time will come, for the Church and the World seem too much allied, at present, in principle and practice. The Saviour says, *Be*

ye sepearate—and if this small, still voice is not obeyed, you may depend upon it he will bring his rod, *for his fan is in his hand, and he will thoroughly purge his floor*. Hence his own declaration, *And I will bring upon thee a day of evil*. This you may feel personally. Also, after having been a little at ease, and careless of God's glory, his cause, and his ways, he may permit you to fall; or by associating with carnal Professors, or the World too much, God may bring on you a rod to drive you from them—and if you should chance to fall, and they know it, though God in mercy, gives you repentance to life, they will be the first to stone you, and like the Priest and Levite, take care to avoid you; and if after this, you maintain the sentiment of human weakness, and insist upon it man is nothing, but as he is made and kept by the grace of God, these stout men, these whole-hearted professors, will hate you and your Doctrines; so Job found, when he said, *He that is ready to slip with his feet, is as a lamp despised in the thought of him that is at ease*. But God may bring on you such an evil day.

Another day of evil is, *Suffering persecution from the world for the truth's sake*; or from those who profess a part of the truth. Such may hate you, nay the Saviour says they *shall* hate you, and say all manner of evil against you—*all manner*, not a few hard and ill-natured things, but any thing disrespectful, spiteful, and disgraceful. This may be the lot of my Brother—this you will find very hard, seeing you have been kind to all, and acted as upright before men as you could, never deserving this from man,—yet meeting with it. Defamation of character, endeavouring to injure you in your situation, trying to prejudice all your friends against you, and to stir up your own household to oppose you. But these things *will* they do to you, because, says the Saviour, *They have not known the Father nor me*. However, you will not be wholly destitute of some who will be raised up for your good. Hence the promise to the persecuted saint, *And I will cause you to be well entreated in the day of evil*. This was God's promise to poor Jeremiah; and the Saviour gives the command, *Let my out-casts dwell with thee, Moab, be thou a covert to him, from the face of the spoiler*.

Thus the Lord will take care of you in time of persecution, national troubles, which the children of God must feel in their degree, through the loss of trade, bankruptcies, a long war, the high price of provisions, and the scarcity of every national blessing; yet, depend upon it, the Lord will find bread for you. So David encourages the people of God, *I have been young*

and now am old, yet I never saw the righteous forsaken nor his seed begging of bread. Or, as the learned say, it should be rendered, *though begging of bread, yet not forsaken.* Bread and water the Lord has promised you, and remembering that you are one of his prisoners, that he is bound to maintain you, Friends will be raised up, a supply will be sent in from the most unlikely quarters. *And the earth helped the woman.—I have commanded the Ravens to feed thee there.* Thus you shall not want in the day of evil. You may meet with many family troubles as Jacob did, and say with that dear Patriarch, at the close of your life, *Few and evil have the days of my life been.* Many evils have I met with from my children and relations, enough to break a heart of stone. My relations were envious, oppressive, cruel, and ungrateful. My children's conduct often pierced my heart.—I have been in many wants and dangers, but the Lord that redeemed me from all evil, has thus far led me on, and I am now going home, for I have waited for thy salvation, O Lord.

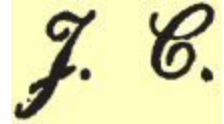
Thus my dear Brother, you may have some days of evil, from family troubles, losses, crosses, and cares. You may have no small opposition from men of corrupt minds, that lay in wait to deceive. Hence the Apostle recommends a clear experimental knowledge of the truth—Christ the essential truth, and the word of God as the revealed truth. A few head notions though very clear, are not able to withstand the artifices of hell, for if a man is argued into a set of notions, he is liable to be argued out of them. When a man of ability, reason, sense, and a vast string of arguments, against the previous truths of the gospel, attacks such as have no grace in the heart, they are soon moved from the truth; but when those are attacked that have felt the precious truths of the gospel in the heart, though the poor believer is not able to answer him one question out of an hundred, he can prove the reality of those truths he holds, because they have done so much for him. The truth has brought him from darkness to light, from sin to holiness, from the service of the devil to the Service of God. Thus He can prove the reality of Bible truth, by his own present experience; and thus he is able to stand in the evil day, the day of rebuke and blasphemy. I can prove the Divinity of God my Saviour; by the answers he has given me to prayer, by the words he has sent to my heart, with power, and by the virtue of his sacrifice, which has lifted up my mind, so as no human power or object could have done, I can likewise prove the Doctrine of the Trinity, by

the operation of the Father's love, the manifestation of the Atonement of the Son, and by the regenerating influences of the Spirit. So we can experimentally prove the truth of every doctrine and divine ordinance. But then, when all my former experience is hid from me; what am I to do, when attacked by my foes in this evil day, and I am as a dumb man, in whose mouth are no reproofs? How shall I act? methinks you are ready to say. To which I must reply, that there is a time to keep silence, and a time to speak; but if shut up in heart and lip, then stand still, and hence the watch word, *Stand! stand! shall they cry, but none shall look back—still abide by the stuff, if you are not able to go out to battle, you shall share alike with those that do. Having done all to stand, stand in the evil day.* Still go on hearing, praying, reading, hoping, and waiting, and whatever errors are thrown into your mind, and have brought it into bondage, you may depend upon it the Lord will deliver you from them; and here you will see sovereign grace, yourself delivered, and the wise and prudent given up to believe a lie. This made the redeemer glad; he rejoiced in spirit and said, *I thank thee, Father, Lord of heaven and earth, that thou hast HID these things from the wise and prudent, and hast revealed them unto babes—even so Father, for so it seemeth good in thy sight.*—Thus may you stand in the days of evil.

But finally; sickness, age, death, and judgment, are days of evil; not that there can be any curse in these things, to one of God's elect, but they will be found such to those who know not God.—These are days in which none but the favourites of Christ can lift up their heads: *the prudent man foreseeth the evil, and hideth himself, but the simple pass on and are punished.* But in times of sickness and age, the brightest saint may suffer much in body, and be afflicted in mind: God may hide his face, Satan may plague, conscience may be uneasy; pain may be great, the spirits may droop; but there is no curse in all these things: one smile from the Saviour will clear all up, and make the soul happy in a sickly body. Hence the promise, *blessed is he that considereth the poor and needy;* even a precious Jesus in his personal or mystical suffering, the Lord will make his bed in his sickness. This my dear brother is acting the part of a kind nurse, he will strengthen you upon the bed of languishing: thus shall my subject be felt in times of sickness and age, even the peculiar blessedness of considering, of remembering our Creator in the days of youth. Death and judgment will be evil times to many of our fallen race, but they must be the crowning days of

all who love *his* appearing. But I must not enlarge, I think I shall tire your patience in this long letter; the sheep are gathering together, I must run with some food for them—'tis past seven o'Clock; God bless thee.

Ever your's in him who is our hiding place, and our shield,

A handwritten signature in black ink, consisting of the letters 'J.' followed by 'C.', set against a yellow rectangular background.

LETTER V.

TO THEOPHILUS.

DEAR FRIEND,

I well remember some conversation which we once had upon the subject of the creation, and feeling my mind particularly imprest with that subject, I venture only to drop a word or two upon it, 'tis a mercy to be satisfied with what God has said; but some are daringly presumptuous, so that they can treat both the Deity and his revelation with contempt. I am glad you are delivered from that snare. The Mosaic account of the Creation has always been supposed to be too weak, simple, and incorrect for a philosophic mind; they vainly suppose the mind ought to have been led through the whole Planetary System, instead of being led to the glorious Work of Redemption, which reflects his highest honour and beauty; for here, and here alone, his brightest form of glory shines.

The six days work of Creation was to open to the eye of faith his works very gradually, that like the stars of a night, they might be seen one by one. The six days work, and the seventh day of rest, was no doubt designed to shadow forth the Seven Millenniums, which would include all time between the two eternities. The first day, from Adam to Enoch, had in it a revelation of the true light—the second, from Enoch to Abraham, including the division of the waters—the third day, from Abraham to David, including the separation of the nations of the world—the fourth day, represented the Thousand Years from Solomon to Christ, the time when the Shekinah appeared in the Temple: the Church, fair as the Moon, and the Prophets, the Stars, shone bright in the firmament. At the close of this, Christ the true Sun appeared. The fifth day was to point out the state of the church and the world, from Christ to the Reformation, when the great Whales of Anti-christian powers, troubled the seas. This lasted till the glorious

Reformation, the beginning of the Sixth Day, in which we now are, and longing for the Seventh, the rest of Jesus and his Bride, in the den of Eden, the glorious Millennium. But infidels object to the Mosaic account of light, the finest emblem of Jesus—there is nothing in the account contrary either to reason or philosophy. I acknowledge the question which philosophers have asked, cannot be solved, the Bible has not engaged to satisfy vain curiosity, viz. *What was that light that made its appearance before the Sun?* A very learned man supposes it to have been an emanation of the same Sun that enlightens us, and which was created though it had not yet appeared in his glory, yet it shed sufficient light to make the Globe visible.—This is not a bad idea for a half-hearted Christian Philosopher.—Milton seems to lean this way when speaking of light—

To journey through the aerial gloom began,
Sphered in a radiant cloud, for yet the Sun
Was not, she in a cloudy tabernacle
Sojourn'd the while.

This is a very pretty idea, nor is it at all contrary to reason any more than the cloud that followed the Israelites which contained a shade, a fire, darkness, and light at the same time. Yet the word of God is true, and to that we must adhere. As light without the sun was first formed, so it appears the great Creator collected these particles of light into one body, the Sun. The language of scripture often expresses the appearance of things to us, such as the Sun rising and setting, which at the same time, perfectly in the main point, agreeing with the Newtonian System of Philosophy. Did light appear first? was it not to notice the dispensation for the four first thousand years, till on the fourth day the Sun of Righteousness should appear? Was it not an emblem of all the light the Church of God has now, till the second appearance of the Son of God in our nature, and of that light which we have till the Saviour shines upon the soul, with healing in his beams? We have light to see ourselves and his glory, but we want him to shine with power, then we shall *be light in the Lord*, till then, light and darkness must struggle together; and God divided them, to shew the difference between the Law and the Gospel—between the Flesh and the Spirit, between the Church and the World—between the Elect and the Reprobate—Christ and Anti-christ. See the light and darkness struggling;

see it soon begins in Cain and Abel, and to this day it continues, and will for ever. The Elect and Reprobate are divided in election, in redemption, in calling, in principles, in practices, in death, judgment, and eternity. May this subject lead you and me to the Saviour, who is the light, the beauty, purity, loveliness, and glory of the Church. O may we see him, love him, adore him, and enjoy him, till we behold him in Heaven.

Permit me to notice further, that the Holy Ghost is pleased to represent various characters and things by these same terms, Sun, Moon, Light, and Stars,—which is really worthy our attention. He sets forth the Lord Jesus by that well known emblem, the Sun, and I think it is the finest figure in nature; and hence that very precious promise to those who are the called according to his purpose, *Unto you that fear my name shall the Sun of righteousness arise with healing in his beams*. Eternal sun, whose morning measures all our days, who hast gradually risen on my dear friend's heart, shine brighter to perfect day, even to that blessed meridian when in our flesh we shall see God.

Sometimes the moon, in scripture, signifies the Church of God as inferior to Christ, the glorious sun, from whom they borrow all their light and truth; their frames and feelings inconstant, spotted in their hearts and lives, which is the cause of much grief to their souls, yet they are the light of this lower world, and their influence is great on the sea of this troubled state.

Light is sometimes used as an emblem of God's word, as pure, glorious, pleasant, and comfortable, penetrating and purifying. While favored with this light, may we walk in it, lest darkness overtake us, as it is written, *Give glory to the Lord your God, before he cause darkness*.—By Stars, in scripture, sometimes the Spirit condescends to point out the Ministers of the Gospel, with all the Ordinances, which are designed, like the Star in the East, to lead to the grand end, the Babe of Bethlehem. These are fixed in the firmament of the Church, for adorning it, and for guiding the spiritual mariner to endless glory, amidst the nights of trouble and woe. These are held in the hands of Christ, kept, supported, and blest by him; and though constantly opposed and troubled, yet shine on, and shine forth. This is the mystery of the Seven Stars. But these are likewise used to point out other things in sacred writ. When God foretold the exaltation of Joseph, in a dream, he shewed him, in a second revelation, the sun, moon, and eleven

stars, bowing down to him; which was afterwards explained by the venerable Patriarch finding an asylum with his son Joseph, and his brethren doing him homage in his state of exaltation.—And was it not a striking type of our truly-exalted spiritual Joseph? honored by the most dignified characters in our world, for kings shall submit themselves to him, and the whole Church of Jesus, the moon, with all the stars, ministers of the Gospel, that should bow before him, and Crown him Lord of all.

I remark again, that when the Saviour predicted the overthrow of Jerusalem, he foretold that the sun should be darkened, that is, that the Lord, who was the light of the Jewish Church, should withdraw his light, justly leave them in judicial blindness, in which they remain to this day—that the moon should be turned into blood, that is, their Synagogue, their Church, which was put to the sword, (at least the greatest part of them)—that the stars should fall—their doctors, rulers over the church and state—which they did. But Solomon, in his 12th of Ecclesiastes, verse 2, seems to borrow these metaphors of sun, moon, light, and stars, and applies them to the human frame, when sickness or old age has impaired it. Good Mr. Henry remarks on this passage—the decays and infirmities of old age are here elegantly set forth in figurative expressions, which have some difficulty in them to us now, who are not acquainted with the phrases and metaphors used in Solomon's age and language. But the general scope is plain, to shew how uncomfortable, generally, the days of old age are. Then he proceeds, and says, that the sun, moon, stars, and light will be dim to old people, through the decay of their sight; their countenance is decayed, and the beauty and lustre of it is eclipsed—their intellectual powers and faculties, which are as light in the soul, are weakened—their understanding and memory fail them, and their apprehension is not so quick, nor their fancy so lively as it has been.—Light is often put for joy and prosperity—the days of their mirth are over, and they have not the pleasure either of the converse by day, or the repose of night, for both the sun and moon was darkened to them; then the clouds return after the rain, as when the weather is disposed to wet, no sooner is one shower blown over but another succeeds it, when one pain is a little abated another comes on—the gout, the rheumatism; and so these afflictions being common to aged persons, they are continually grieved.

That famous commentator, Patrick, observes on this verse, that the words intimate the universal decay of the whole frame of nature, and a failing of the mind in all its faculties and powers—that something particular is signified by every word; that by the sun is meant the soul itself; by the light the understanding, by the moon his will, by the stars all the motion of the mind and memory, with all the affections and powers in the will. So the sense of the wise man is thus—the mind of man grows feeble in all its powers, the understanding dim-sighted, the memory forgetful, the reason weak and childish, giving even a feeble light, that can neither direct ourselves or others. The will listless in all its desires, dull about our greatest concerns, wavering and inconstant in all resolutions, and so on. But the interpretation first mentioned seems most consistent.

Surely then, my Brother, these are some of the evil days which are hastening on us, and though we may not live to see old age, yet, through affliction we may have all our faculties as much impaired as the most ancient person in the world; this has been very often seen.—What a mercy I do consider it, that *he* who hath begun the good work in my heart, can carry it on without my aid, or the concurrence of my powers or faculties working with him. Say not it is my duty to do so and so, in and with the work of the Spirit: *Thou, Lord*, says the Church, *shall work all our works in us, and ordain peace for us*. But while we would look forward to the evil days which must come on the body, may we not notice some evil days that our souls may meet with, when the all-healing, comfortable, soul-reviving, soul-cheering, heart-warming beams of Christ, the glorious Sun of Righteousness shall be with-held, and coldness, deadness, sickness, darkness, legality, and distance is felt; and such seasons have befel the brightest saints. Hence the mournful cry, *Why hidest thou thy face, O Lord? thou hidest thy face and we are troubled*, about our state, our feelings, our wants, our prospects, our way, our end. We always know when we feel him shine and when we do not, though, as it respects himself, he is just the same in his shining, but we are not sensible of it by reason of the cloud that cometh betwixt. When we feel this wretched state we are always ready to fly to means, though we ought never to neglect them; yet there is a proneness in us to cleave to something short of the main subject. But, alas, we find the moon of Ordinances is just as dark! We move backwards and forwards, like the door on its hinges, yet get neither dew nor rain, light, life,

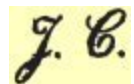
comfort, nor joy. At the table of the Lord we neither feel love nor pity for our dear Saviour. In singing his praises we have no heart, in associating with his people we get nothing from them; if they talk of joys, we have none! if of a broken-heart, we feel nothing but hardness—if of light or comfort, we feel destitute of both—thus the moon gives no light. As to ministers, they don't seem to touch our case, nor is their word cloathed with any power. We fancy they are very much altered in their preaching—we change them: the passions are stirred up for a little while, but we find we are in just the same state. Hence the spouse is represented as having lost her lover—she rises, runs, seeks, mourns, and is still disappointed. *I sought him but I found him not.* Then she went into the broad places of public worship, then into the streets, among the inhabitants; after this to ministers, to enquire, *how? why? and wherefore?* But, for a season, all was still dark, yes, very dark indeed: these stars seem to give but little light during such painful seasons: the scriptures of light shut up in their beautiful histories, promises, types, parables, and doctrines, where we could see Christ once in every part, and enjoy him; now, alas, it is not so, but it is as a spring shut up, and sealed from us. While this is attended with a lowering sky, and a continual dropping of rain; no bright clouds now return as they used to do, and how it is with us we cannot tell. Once if we felt a little dark or uncomfortable, it was soon gone, smiling hope used to spring up, or a promise sent home with power. The company of God's people cheered us up, or a little access to God's throne revived us. Seldom heard a sermon but we got something by it—and if a few storms of persecution, temptation or corruption, or family trials befel us, the Lord made a bright cloud after it; but, alas, it is not thus with us now, these clouds don't return after the rain—thus

Afflictions like vapours may rise,
Light, love, and delight may be gone;
The sun may be dark in the skies,
And hell with its legions come on!

Ah, my dear Brother, these are dark days truly, but it shall not be always thus; *to the upright there arises light in darkness*—this light is sown for us, and shall spring up again.

But may I not here enquire, as on another occasion, the Prophet did, *Shall there be an evil in the City and the Lord hath not done it? Is there not a cause? Why doth a living man (a quickened man) complain?* Let us enquire the cause: Have you not been making too much of your comforts? Have you not been looking at them instead of the Saviour, living on them instead of his fulness?—and were you not too prone to slight those who had not attained the same consolation? And, if so, Can you wonder that God should permit a partial death to overtake you?—Or, perhaps, there may be other causes—a sad neglect of those means which are appointed for the spiritual health of the soul: as abstinence, or neglect of food, will soon bring the body into a pining, languishing condition, so, if the means of the knowledge of grace be not diligently attended to and implored, our souls must get into a starving state. The indulgence of sensual pleasures may bring on deadness, darkness, and distance. See this in Sampson, while sleeping in the lap of Delilah, he was shorn of his strength; and he arose to shake himself as at other times, but he wist not that the Lord had departed from him. But perhaps the Lord has done this to shew his adorable sovereignty, as in the case of Job: hence his complaint, *He hath fenced up my way that I cannot pass, and he hath set darkness in my path.* And so complains Jeremiah, *He hath led me, and brought me into darkness, and not into light.* Sometimes this is done to humble us, lest we should be exalted above measure. But, above all, the Spirit leads into these deep and painful feelings, to make us prize our adorable Redeemer, and see our continual need of being supplied from his fulness. He lets our cisterns run dry, that we may come and lay our vessels under the flowings of the blessed fountain of life, that from him we might receive grace for grace.

May great grace rest on you. I remain
Your willing Servant in Christ,

A small, handwritten signature in black ink, reading "J. C.", is placed on a yellow rectangular background.

LETTER VI.

TO THEOPHILUS.

DEAR BROTHER,

I OWE you a long epistle, for the many kind letters I have received from you. This acknowledgment of my debt is a part of payment. Being a little confined through indisposition of body, I thought I would pen a few thoughts to my dear friend, trusting they will be acceptable at this time.

I am more than ever delighted with the pleasing theme the Gospel exhibits of our most adorable Lord, of whom it is written, *that in all our afflictions he was afflicted; that he was the subject of all sinless infirmities; that he was a man like ourselves, sin only excepted.* This is a sweet thought to me, under every pressure; and surely it proves our union with him, and a participation of his Spirit, of course of the same covenant privileges. What a Christ have we got! God with God, Man with Man, very God and very Man; a kind brother, to feel with and for me, under all my trials, and a God able to supply my every need; and what adds a glory to this point is, that as God-Man he is the glorious Mediator, commissioned to give all I need; for this purpose he hath ascended upon high and received gifts for the rebellions! This is a most charming consideration, it is the joy of my heart; I feel it so—and such an High Priest became us: O! for an heart to bless him, to praise him as I ought, as I wish to do! I long to be disembodied for this purpose. O could my soul leap out of her dull clay, scarce should a harp above aim at a sweeter, nobler song, *Unto him that hath loved me.* My dear brother, I feel mortality, I am at times very glad of it: I have had much sickness of late, it is a signal, it is a knock, it is a servant sent with a message. Mark the command, *Look, as when the messenger cometh, and shut to the door: is not the sound of his master's feet behind him?* I keep the messenger; I retire; I read the note, Thus saith my Master, *Behold I come*

quickly; I can send no answer back but thus—*Even so come, Lord Jesus*. May I therefore esteem every pain, every felt weakness, and every beating pulse, but as so many messengers sent in covenant love, to remind me of my mortality—that this is not my rest, that my whole bodily frame is but as a Shepherd's tent, as Hezekiah calls it, soon unpinned, easily taken down, and removed, as the Arabian Shepherd's tents were.—Hence the scriptures in a variety of places shew that the body is but earth, dust and ashes, formed of it, lives on it, and must soon return to it. The apostle calls the body an outward man, which must decay, while the inward man, the hidden man of the heart, is renewed day by day, by the secret influences of the Spirit. This work is carried on by a continual application of Gospel promises, and tokens of love: this inward man gets renewed day by day, till we arrive to perfect day. This is going from strength to strength, and being changed from glory to glory. This body is the temple of the Holy Ghost, the object of God's Love, and the purchase of the precious blood of Jesus. This frame is called by Solomon, an house, built up in infinite wisdom, supported by Almighty power, and is the noblest workmanship of Jehovah. Compared to an house, the understanding faculty is the windows, the receptive capacity is the door; and as the soul is converted to God, the will and the affections is the throne, the principal seat of Jesus; the graces of the Spirit is the furniture, and Father, Son, and Spirit, are the glorious and ever blessed inhabitants thereof, where they will dwell for ever. The Body, only, I am about to notice.

I acknowledge I am not much skilled in Anatomy, it is a science I never learned, though I believe the best Anatomist is a person who can dissect the human heart. Yet the body being the great work of God, I would view it with wonder, with admiration, and praise. I dare say you are sometimes amazed at this wonderful, curious-wrought frame; this wonderful display of divine skill. Permit me just to notice only a very few things, though you are so well acquainted with anatomy. I trust you will correct me where I err, in considering this earthly house of our tabernacle. I must refer you to the excellent Hervey's description of the human frame, in his 12th Dialogue of Theron and Aspasio, which I beg you to read: that excellent author observes, first, the *Bones*, cast into a variety of moulds, enlarged or contracted into a variety of sizes, all strong, that they may bear up the fleshy machine, yet light, that they may not depress the animal with an

encumbering load. Insensible themselves, they are covered with a membrane of exquisite sensibility. The *Feet* compose the firmest and neatest pedestal, capable of altering its form and extending its size, containing a set of the nicest springs, which help to place the body in a variety of graceful attitudes; the *Legs* and *Thighs* are like substantial and stately columns, forced in such a manner as is quite commodious to the acts of either walking or sitting. The *Ribs* turned into a regular arch, are gently moveable for the act of respiration; they form a secure lodgment for the lungs and the heart, and fortify them. The back bone is intended, not only to strengthen the body, and sustain its most capacious store rooms, but also to bring down that communication of the Brain, which is usually termed the Spinal Marrow, and guards the silver cord. The *Arms* are exactly proportioned to each other; these being the guards which defend, and the ministers which serve the whole body, are fitted for the most extensive operations, firm with bone, yet not weighty with flesh; they bend inwards or turn outwards, they rise upwards or stoop downwards, and they throw themselves into whatever direction we please. To these are annexed the *Hands*, and all terminated by the *Fingers*, which give a most graceful appearance, yet destined to almost incessant employ; though the extremities or the fingers are an assemblage of the finest fibres, most acutely sensible; for this reason our Almighty Maker has overlaid them with an horny substance called *Nails*, to preserve the tender part from dangerous impressions. Above all, is *the Head*, a majestic dome, designed for the residence of the Brain; ample to receive it, strong to uphold it, and firm to defend it. This stately Capital, is screened from heat, defended from cold, and at the same time much beautified by a copious growth of Hair, which no ways encumbers the wearer. This is the *outward* Man, the noble work of the great God our Saviour, who became man for our sakes.

It is equally as wonderful to notice the *Inside* of this house; with the amazing arrangement of Fibres that unite the several Limbs of the Body, tough and strong. The small *Membranes* appointed, enwrap the fleshy parts, to part some, and form a connection with the others. *Arteries*, some of which ascend to the Head, others spread themselves over the shoulders; some extend to the Arms, and others descend to the Feet. *Veins*, these are appointed to receive the blood from the arteries, and reconvey it to the heart. *Glands*, whose office it is to filtrate the passing fluid; an assemblage

of *vessels*, complicated and interwoven with seeming confusion, but with perfect regularity. *Muscles*, wove in nature's finest loom, seem composed of the slenderest fibres, yet indeed with incredible strength; these, with their tendons, constitute the instruments of motion; not like a sluggish beast, but quick as lightning. *Nerves*, surprisingly minute tubes, derived from the Brain, which gliding into the Muscles, set them on work, depress the power of sensation through the body, or returning upon any impression from without, give all needful intelligence to the soul. The *Skin*, like a curious surtout, exactly fitted, is superadded over the whole, formed of the most delicate net work. The *Pores* are minute, and nervous fibres are multiplied even to a progeny.—The *Veins* beautifying the human structure, especially the most conspicuous parts of it; the pliant wrist and the taper arm, are adorned with them, they spread vermillion over the lips, and plant roses on the cheeks; while the eye, tinged with glossy jet, or sparkling with the blue of Heaven, is fixed in an orb of polished crystal.

The grand means of keeping up this wonderful frame, is a point worthy our attention; for this purpose it is furnished with the powers of nutrition. *Teeth*, the foremost thin and sharp, fit to bite asunder, or cut off such a portion as the mouth can conveniently manage: those which are broad and strong are qualified to grind in pieces whatever is transmitted to their operation. The *Throat*, the *Stomach*, with its various operations and appendages, which are so admirably constructed, I leave you to muse upon. There are but two things more I have time to notice. High in the Head, and conspicuous, as a star in the evening, is placed the *Eye*. This is one of the greatest works of our blessed Creator, consisting only of simple fluids, inclosed in thin tunics: it conveys to our apprehension all the graces of blooming nature, and all the glories of the visible heavens. The *Eye* so particularly tender, that a slight accident, scarce perceivable by any other part of the body, would be very injurious to its delicate frame. It is intrenched deep in the Head, and barricaded on every side with a strong fortification of bones, defended by two substantial curtains, hung on a slender rod, which secures it from every troublesome annoyance. The *Ear*. The structure of this organ is so wonderful that God claims it as his own work, *He that planted the Ear*. Amazing nice and exact must be the formation and the tension of the auditory nerve, since they correspond with the smallest tremors of the atmosphere: these living chords, tuned by an

Almighty hand, receive the impressions of sound, and propagate them to the Brain. These give existence to the charms of music, and the entertainment of discourse. I must not enlarge—read the whole of that Chapter, and no doubt you will be well entertained.

But while I would admire this noble work of God, I rejoice that Jesus has taken my nature, and lives in it for ever; and that he will raise my frame from the disgrace of corruption, earth, and worms, to glory, happiness, and God. I am at the same time deeply affected with the miseries of my fallen nature, in consequence of sin; this has injured all its fine powers, damaged every room in this wonderful house, so that in consequence of the bad tenants which occupy it, the Almighty landlord has ordered us to quit it. We have received by many a pain, a writ of ejectment, but being unwilling to leave this clay frame, though in such a damaged state, the owner and builder of this house takes it down by degrees, which, Solomon mentions in the following four verses. Ah! my brother, what has sin done! the pains, miseries, strife, and agonies introduced into our poor bodies, and distress into our souls. Permit me here to mention that affecting description which the Angel gave to Adam, soon after his fall, as represented by Milton.—

—Immediately a place

Before his eyes appear'd, sad, noisome, and dark;
A lazarus house it seem'd, wherein were laid
Numbers of all diseases; all maladies,
Of ghastly spasm, or racking torture, qualms
Of heart-sick agony, all feverous kinds,
Convulsions, epilepsies, fierce catarrhs,
Intestine stone and ulcer, colic-pangs,
Demoniac phrensies, moping melancholy,
And moon-struck madness, pining atrophy,
Marasmus, and wide-wasting pestilence,
Dropsies, and asthmas, and joint-racking rheums.
Dire was the tossing, deep the groans; despair
Tended the sick, busiest from couch to couch;
And over them triumphant death his dart
Shook, but delay'd to strike, though oft invoc'd
With vows, as their chief good, and final hope.
Sight so deform'd what heart of rock could long

Dry-ey'd behold? Adam could not, but wept,
Though not of woman born; compassion-quell'd
His best of man, and gave him up to tears.

From this sight let us turn, likewise, and consider the infinite love and condescension of God our dear Saviour, who took all our infirmities, bore our sickness, and knows how to sympathize with our poor natures in all their sorrows; and such an High Priest became us; such a Saviour is exactly adapted for all our miseries; and hence he is called a Physician of value, he healeth all our diseases, and surely the mind is awfully diseased with sin, nothing but his skill can penetrate into the depth of the diseases of the mind; whatever may be the ailments of the body, they are but emblems of the diseases of the soul; the blindness of ignorance, the deafness of spiritual unconcern, the fever of concupiscence, the jaundice of malice, the swelling tympany of pride, the vertigo of inconstancy, the quinsey of cursing and blasphemy, the dropsy of covetousness, the palsey of stupidity, the pleurisy of envy, the rheumatism of discontent, the delirium of constant levity, the moon-struck madness of passion and rage, with unbelief, hardness of heart, temptations of Satan, and the stings of conscience, of whatever disease we may feel we have got; these the adorable Physician heals. Let us carry all our hard cases to him—*See Brown's Tropology*. We are always welcome to him, and though he may not seem to notice our case for a season, yet he will in his own appointed time. This text has often been very precious to my soul, *Therefore will the Lord wait that he may be gracious to you—and therefore will he be exalted that he may have mercy upon you*.

Finally, The earthly house of our tabernacle shall soon be dissolved, it has got the plague in it, the plague of leprosy, and the house is condemned to come down. Leviticus xiv. *He shall break down the house, the stones of it, and the timber of it, and all the mortar of the house, and he shall carry them forth out of the city into an unclean place, even to the grave, till the last trumpet shall sound, and the tabernacle be raised again, beautiful and glorious, like the human nature of our most glorious Covenant Head; and this will be thy lot, O Theophilus, as sure as the trumpet of the Gospel ever quickened your soul.*

I shall add no more, but my prayers for you, as I trust I have your's for me.

J. C.

LETTER VII.

TO MRS. D—.

Peckham, July 11, 1814.

MY DEAR FRIEND.

MAY the Father of Mercies and God of all consolation be with you, as your all in all, the foundation of your soul, the shield of your faith, the helmet of your hope, the length of your days, the joy of your mind, the strength of your heart, and your portion for ever.

I think, a few months ago you requested, and I promised you, a few remarks on the 12th of Ecclesiastes. Having repeated it in the Pulpit in a Sermon, I will now endeavour to give you my opinion in the most literal and spiritual manner I can, with all due deference to superior judgments; and humbly submit my sentiments to the whole Church of Christ, which is the pillar and the ground of the truth.

It has been asserted that Solomon was the wisest of all men; here I beg leave to differ, I humbly conceive he was not so wise as Adam, before the fall; nor perhaps so wise as the Apostle Paul: but when it is said he was the wisest of men, it must be considered merely in a political point of view; as God blest him with much natural wisdom, so that he was able to manage the affairs of the Nation without a Parliament, and to try all causes without a Bench of Judges; this was indeed a great work, and the Lord fitted him for it, by a spirit of wisdom and understanding, which he requested of the Lord. He was the wisest man, therefore, in natural things, that perhaps ever lived since the fall.—He collected and framed three thousand Proverbs, and a thousand and five spiritual Songs. He was well versed in, and well explained the nature of Herbs and Animals of every kind. Solomon had several books to study, the Book of the Ceremonial Law, which is often

alluded to in the Proverbs, the Book of the Moral Law, out of which he was taught his need of a Mediator, and a better righteousness than his own, to justify him before God, the Book of all the scriptures that were then extant. Into these he was deeply led. He had the book of nature, and appeared to be a Master of all the Sciences of natural and spiritual Philosophy. He was well skilled in Astronomy, in Botany, and Anatomy; the last he shews his skill in, as this last chapter of the Preacher shews. This book was probably written in his old age, after his recovery from his fall, and God had healed his broken bones. Age and sorrow coming on him, he felt the decline of mortality, urges the necessity of spiritual knowledge and practice, while health lasts and God furnishes a man with opportunities, knowing that the mental faculties would soon decay, however bright they might have been. These are set forth in three verses. He then notices the decay of the human frame—its weakness, and how every limb and joint, every power and passion, every member and faculty is affected, either by age, sickness, or trouble. The Lord, indeed, sometimes sends for his dear people, suddenly. He snatches them away from the power of enemies, and the evil to come; but others are gently gathered, not hastily plucked. God takes down our tabernacle a pin at a time, and loosens the cords just as we are able to bear it; gives kind warnings, and then appears like a cloud of the latter rain. This gradual decay Solomon pays a particular attention to, he had noticed it in others, perhaps began to feel it himself; and having called the Body an House, he describes its timbers, its strong beams, its supporters; *in the day when the keepers of the house shall tremble and the strong men bow themselves*. The almost universally received opinion of these *Strong men, the keepers of the house*, is, that they signify the *Hands and Feet*, which include the *Shoulders*, the *Arms*, and *Hands*, the *Thighs*, the *Legs*, and the *Feet*.—These Hands and Arms are the keepers of the house, for when the scripture speaks of preserving, defence, and deliverance, the Hands and Arms are generally mentioned, besides, they keep the house by providing for it, getting maintenance for the whole body. *These Hands*, says Paul, *have ministered to my necessities*: these protect the house, and also keep off an adversary; these tremble through age or infirmities, as experience shews; and this includes all weakness and inactivity of those parts in this condition, whether they are outward, as stiffness and contraction, or inward, as aches, pains, numbness, palsies, cramps, and tremblings. Thus the Keepers tremble. The wise Man then descends to notice the inferior, the *Feet*,

containing these parts in connection, the Thighs, Legs, Ancles, and Feet. These are the strong men; sometimes they are called the Strength of a man; and the Spouse is setting forth the majesty and glory of her beloved, in his strength, by this text, *His legs are as pillars of marble*; and because the great strength of a Man lays in these parts, therefore in his infirm and weak condition, these parts must become more eminently weak. As the diseases which affect the superior part, also affect the inferior, as the rheumatism, gout, and such like, the keepers and the strong men are subject to a similarity of diseases; and the learned say they are in the original exprest nearly alike—*The keepers of the house tremble, and the strong men shall nod, or shake.*

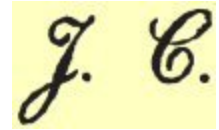
The next part of this shakey house the Wise Man observes, is the *Grinders*; these cease, because they are few. Grinding, all men know to be performed by two hard bodies, the one immovable, on which the Grinding is made, the other movable; which by strong compression against the former, and by its motion, makes the grinding. The upper and the nether millstone, as the scripture calls them, the firm stander, and the strong mover. Now, similar unto these in a mill, there are for that grinding which is performed in the mouth, two jaw-bones, the upper and lower; the upper admits no movement at all, the lower is movable, and so both perform that act called mastication, or chewing. Out of these jaw-bones proceed a certain number of small bones, we call *Teeth*—these are the proper *strict* instruments of grinding. By the ceasing of the Teeth, we must understand all those infirmities that are incident to them by reason of age, whether looseness, hollowness, rottenness, brokenness, blackness, or whatever else may be an impediment to them in their use; for as age comes on, the natural moisture at the root of the teeth is consumed, and a preternatural is distilled in its room: thus as the teeth drop out, and very few are left in it, the chewing in the mouth ceaseth, more so than when there is none at all, for then the gums might act one against another. But when the grinders are few, they hinder those from working, and having no antagonists they are not able to work themselves, and so the whole grinding ceaseth, which is a great symptom of the decay of life, at least of a state of weakness.

The next great object which we are called to observe, is, the *Decay of Sight*—*Those that look out of the windows, are darkened.* I believe none has ever questioned but this means the eyes, and the infirmities of them in old

age. One may be said to look out of a window, when he looks through the glass of the window, or when he looks through the open casement. Now a man could not look through a window, if it was not made of glass, or something of the kind, neither could he perceive any thing with his eye were not the parts thereof which the passage is made of, the very same substance. The parts of the eye through whose bodies the visible *species* must pass, that they may be discerned, are either the humours, or the tunics; the humours are three, the watery, the chrystalline, and glossy humour, so Anatomists call them; and however they differ, yet they are all instrumental to vision. The tunics or coats, through which the sight is made, are only two, though there are others which conduce to the sight, yet there are but two through which the beams of light pass; the first is as fine and curious as a Spider's web, and being derived from the Brain and optic Nerve, it becomes a vestment for the humors, and is pellucid and transparent. The other is an hard and horny membrane, and encompasseth the whole body of the eye, without perforation, and on the back part, behind the sight of the eye is more obscure and dark, but on the fore part is far more plain and clear. Solomon observes these *lookers out of the windows to become dark*, that is, as age enfeebleth the eye the form and figure becomes more plane and depressed than it was before, and the chrystalline humor, which had a power of reducing itself, now becomes dry and altogether unfit for such an end, which must breed a confusion in the sight. As age comes on, and increaseth, it is well known the sight goeth away, the lookers out of the windows must be darkened. We have scarce any description in scripture of an old man and his infirmities, but the decrease of sight is mentioned, their eyes were dim, and they could not see.

I hope you will pardon this very short description of the eye, as it is a very large subject, and a vast deal may be said open it, which I reluctantly omit, lest I should swell this letter to a volume.—Thus my dear friend, our poor bodies in sickness and age, are compared to an old house, with its teams, pillars, and windows, terribly shattered; condemned by the Parish to come down. But I cannot let this letter pass without the promise of another. May your confidence increase, and abound more and more in this blessed truth, *If this earthly house of our tabernacle is dissolved, we have a building of God, an house not made with hands, eternal in the heavens*—there may we meet.—Amen.

I remain ever yours in Jesus,

A handwritten signature in black ink on a yellow rectangular background. The signature consists of the letters 'J.' followed by a space and then 'C.'. The 'J' is written in a cursive style with a long, sweeping tail that loops under the dot. The 'C' is also cursive, with a small loop at the top and a tail that curves back towards the letter.

LETTER VIII.

TO MRS. D—.

Peckham, July 21, 1814.

MY DEAR FRIEND,

What an unspeakable blessing it is for you, that the Holy Ghost has enabled you to rejoice in hope of eternal glory, and put that expression in your mouth, as well as the hope and confidence in your heart, *I know that if this earthly house of my tabernacle were dissolved, I have a building above, an house not made with hands, eternal in the heavens*—this is in your hope, and a God of truth has declared your expectation shall not be cut off. The blessed Spirit is promised to all the Elect seed, as the earnest of that promised rest. While the glorious operations of that self-same Spirit, are designed to prepare us for that glorious inheritance. My dear Sister has, I trust, been long taught the sad state of man by nature, that though he was originally built for God to dwell in, and his image did reside in man a little while, yet an enemy came against this little City, besieged it, and raised awful bulwarks against it, gained the possession of the capital, and keeps it in peace, till the stronger than he, even the eternal Spirit comes on him, spoils him of his armour, makes him quit his territory, and gets full possession of his heart. Solomon well instructed in the operations of the Spirit, under the emblems of old age and its infirmities, points out this work in striking, figurative language. *In the days when the keepers of the house shall tremble, and the strong men shall bow themselves.* We are not at a loss to conjecture who those keepers are in the worst of senses, Satan having blinded the eyes of man, it is his work, to study how to keep them blind, keep them enemies, keep them in prejudice, keep them proud, and keep them in awful rebellion. This is the work of the devil, nor is he at a loss for means to carry on this work. Religious systems, and erroneous

preachers, are the Devil's under-strappers, by whom he carries on his infernal work. Hence the out-cry made against the truth, whenever and wherever it is preached; the endeavours to stop the progress of truth in the world, lest the light of the glorious Gospel should shine into the heart, and poor sinners be saved. These strong keepers of the house tremble at the approach of the light of the Gospel, and as soon as it comes in power they must submit, bow themselves, relinquish their claim, and turn out, knowing they come in by art, and with a view to deceive the house, that it might share the same fate as devils do. But viewing this subject experimentally, the Spirit coming to convince of sin, to apply the law to the conscience, and to shew us the works of the devil, at his coming these keepers tremble, but we do not find them gone, till the power of the Gospel is felt. Many have trembled at the curse of the Law; at the preaching of the Law as Felix did, when Paul reasoned of judgment, temperance, and righteousness. It is one thing for a criminal to tremble in his chains, and another for Satan to be overthrown. Satan will maintain his seat in the heart as long as he can, but God says, *I will overturn, overturn, overturn it, until he comes, whose right it is; and I will give it him.*—There is nothing Satan hates so much as light, when this comes into the mind he is discovered, his works hated, and the poor sinner votes against both him and his works, cries unto the Lord because of these oppressors, while his hope springs up in the Gospel news, that the Son of God was manifested in the flesh, that he might destroy the works of the devil, as the power of the word is felt, as grace reigns, so these keepers and strong ones bow, and like the soldiers at the sepulchre, the keepers thereof became as dead men. When the Angel of the covenant descends to open the prison doors, the poor prisoner comes forth as Peter did, from his prison, though the keepers stand at the door they are not able to retain the captive; hence the question, *Shall not the prey be taken from the mighty? Shall not the lawful captive be delivered?* Yes, blessed be God it is the mighty work of God the Spirit to cast down the strong holds of the devil, carnal enmity, pride, prejudice, and self-righteousness; when these are demolished, Satan has no hope of the damnation of such a soul; though the poor sinner himself cannot perhaps see his own part and lot in the salvation of the Gospel; he may still remain in bondage to the fears of death, the dread of hell; unbelief still prevails, doubts, fears, and sad despondency may still operate to keep the soul in misery, till the Holy Ghost favours it with an increase of faith, gives it strength enough to

believe in his love, in his Person and in his glorious Work; then we enter into rest. This is done by believing the report of the Gospel, by believing such precious truths as these: *He shall finish transgression—he shall make an end of sin. He shall magnify the law. Blotting out the handwriting contained in Ordinances, that was against us. Ye are complete in him, having forgiven us all our trespasses. I have loved thee, I have redeemed thee. I have blotted out as a cloud thy transgression, and as a thick cloud thy sins. He hath made to meet on him the iniquities of us all. The Lord is well pleased with his righteousness sake.*

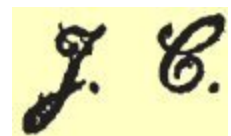
Now, my dear friend, I can assure you that I always feel peace and joy in believing these precious truths for myself; they are for such poor sinners as I have described; but faith to receive these precious things is the gift of God. And this work of God carries us above our strong fears and doubts, which are as much the corruptions of the human heart as our sins. This glorious conquest of the keepers and strong men is sometimes achieved by sensible tokens, clear deliverances, and open manifestations; it was not so with me, but it has been the happy experience of many who have had much legal bondage; not favored with a clear ministry of the word, and when God intends them either for much suffering or for public usefulness. I have often wished it my case, but I should be sorry to endure what many have, nor would I murmur that my heavenly Father has not drove me into such awful deeps.—This portion of scripture I get into very well; *to you which believe he is precious*; yea, he is preciousness itself: This I find true in my experience, and it is enough to convince me that the good work is begun, that the work is of God, and must terminate in an exceeding and eternal weight of glory. Thus we see, feel, and admire the conquests of sovereign Grace; this brings us to God, this endears the Saviour, this inspires us with a lively hope, this turns our feet to God's testimonies, opens the eyes to see the beauty of God's word; the glories of the Saviour, and imbitters, yea, darkens all terrestrial objects. The eyes by nature are full of evil, they are fixed on sinful objects, they are full of sin.—Hence we read of *eyes full of adultery*. We read of lofty eyes, and of an evil eye, the one signifies pride of self-righteousness, the other of a churlish, envious disposition. These eyes must become dark, dim, and least exercised as grace reigns. The lust of the eye is, and must be the grief of all who feel it; with this temptation Satan beset poor Eve; she saw the tree was good; she soon fell after this.

Satan plied this to the Saviour, but in vain. He shewed him all the kingdoms of the world, and the glory of them, in a moment of time. The eye is the inlet of sin; hence Job says, *I have made a covenant with my eyes; why then should I think on a maid.* Job xxxi, verse 1. The power of almighty grace most effectually *at times*, affects the very sight of the believer, and makes him delight in looking into the Word of God, and employing even his very eyes as well as every other faculty, in the good ways of God; and as these are open to every thing that is good, they must be darkened to what is evil, neither the heart nor the eyes of a believer, *as converted*, are designedly set to evil; but when the one wanders and the other slides back from God, it is then the soul mourns,

Prone to wander, Lord I feel it,
Prone to leave the God I love!

This Subject may lead us to further experimental remarks, I do not decidedly pretend to fix the mind of the Holy Ghost on this passage, but while I contemplate the keepers of the house, in the worst sense, may we not look at them in a better point of view; as faith, hope, fear, and love, the christian's keepers; the believer's strong men, who have done much for the Church. Paul has given us a whole chapter on what faith has done, 11th of Hebrews. Hope keeps us at an anchor, firm in our confidence, though it may be small in enjoyment. Fear will never let us wholly depart from God, while love bears us up, and carries us through difficulties, duties, and dangers, and abides with us for ever. These graces are not self-active, they cannot act but as the Spirit keeps them up; they are always in us as spiritual principles, but they are set always active, though perhaps all the ways in which they operate are not known to us. These are very strong in time of tribulation; at least in most cases. Faith is tried deeply when guilt is felt on the conscience, when Satan roars, when the mind is distressed, when outward circumstances run crooked; then faith often leans towards the Atonement; trusts in an unseen, though not an unknown God; waits on God till light springs up, and is looking for suitable promises to support the soul, to plead with God, and to animate the mind at a future day. Thus faith keeps us from sinking. *I had fainted unless I had believed to see the goodness of the Lord in the land of the living.*

But Solomon found some days in his experience when these keepers were not so strong; when these strong men bowed through weakness, and when his sight was not so well occupied, nor his mind quite so clear. He found something, as Sampson did, which weakened his strength, which might have made him question the reality of his faith, the sincerity of his love, and the foundation of his hope, when he found the hedge of Godly fear broken down, and himself at a sad distance from God, befooled in his old age, and led into awful idolatry. When conscience was awakened, and the hand of God was upon him, he then found the keepers were weak indeed; Love had been out of exercise, and the inordinate love of women came in; fear was out of exercise, and idolatry was soon practised, a sin God detests more than any other. Faith was inactive, and hope at a low ebb, so that Satan stept in when these keepers were weak. And is not this, at times, the painful experience of God's Elect, in their degree? Do we not find every sin indulged weakens the graces of the Spirit, beclouds our evidences, and brings us low; so that as soon as trouble comes on, we find neither faith nor hope, nor love, nor fear, nor zeal, nor spirituality. A worldly spirit, levity, evil tempers, giving way to our most easy besetment; hearkening to Satan, conforming to the world, or meddling with erroneous sentiments. These things will weaken, and make the strong men tremble. Guilt felt, sin creeping in between conscience and God, and faith not strong enough to make use of the Atonement; this makes us tremble indeed, while the eyes of an illuminated understanding become very dim—this darkness we feel when we can neither see the way behind nor before with pleasure. Ah! how painful, how truly wretched is this for God's children—*but the backslider in heart shall be filled with his own ways*. What a painful subject is this I am writing to you; but yet it is necessary to know these things; such knowledge is painful, but it is good to write thus to warn, having tasted this bitter cup myself. Here we see the necessity of abiding continually in Jesus, keeping near him, that we may have peace maintained in the conscience; be kept from sin, and led on in the ways of God, strong in faith, cheerful in hope, fervent in love, and tender in conscience. May that be your felicity and mine, dear Sister in Jesus, is the earnest prayer of ever yours in Jesus.

A handwritten signature in black ink on a yellow rectangular background. The signature consists of the letters 'J.' followed by 'C.' in a cursive, slightly stylized font.

LETTER IX.

TO MRS. D—.

Peckham, August 4, 1814.

MY DEAR FRIEND,

GRACE and peace be yours. I am come to visit you once more with pen and ink, though I am not able to come in person to see you. This is a means of conversation the Almighty has afforded us, nor can we be too thankful for it, as we may write to each other on those momentous subjects which concern our never dying souls; nor can the pen be better employed than in stirring up each other's mind, by way of remembrance. Time with us both is short; you are farther advanced in years than I am, but both are going to our Father's house; let us therefore follow that advice of the Wise Man's while we can, *Whatsoever thy hand findeth to do, do it with all thy might, for there is no work, nor device, nor knowledge, nor wisdom, in the grave whither thou goest.*

It is the work of faith to lay hold of eternal life. The knowledge of faith gives present peace; the wisdom of faith is to cleave to God, and the art or device of faith is to endeavour to gain all it can, to be useful to others. This faith leads us to think God's thoughts, and approve of them; to do what Jesus has commanded—to carry our cases to God; to search diligently into his word, and to open the mouth for God when we have an opportunity.—Faith opens the mouth to God in prayer and praise, and for God's glory, in a firm, warm, decided attachment to his cause, his people, his ways, his truth; and while we are favoured with health and means, let us improve them. The faculty of speech, the opening of the lips, and the exercise of the lungs, should be all employed in his service and to his glory, who died, the just for the unjust, to bring us to God. Age, infirmities, trials, and death itself, will

soon put an end to these; let us therefore employ them while we can, and in the lively hope of glory, may we sing, with the excellent *Cowper*,

And when this lisping stammering tongue,
Lies silent in the grave,
Then in a nobler sweeter song,
I'll sing thy power to save.

Hence Solomon exhorts to these things in your favourite chapter, which I glanced at in my last letter. He reminds us of the solemn period to which we are all hastening, *when the doors shall be shut in the street; the sound of the grinding be low, and he shall rise up at the voice of the bird, and all the Daughters of Music shall be brought low.*

I believe I have already intimated that Solomon, was well versed in the science of Anatomy; that he well understood the human frame, and perhaps much better than any before him. He had in the former verse spoken of the Animal System; in this fourth verse he proceeds to notice the Natural Faculties, inward and outward. A great writer says these words form but one sentence: *The doors shall be shut in the streets, when the sound of the grinding is low.* This Grinding is supposed to relate to almost every part in man, which is preserved, kept up, and supported by food, and respects the alteration which that food undergoes, that it may be really transubstantiated into our flesh. These are by Physicians called digestion or concoction. By the *sound* of the Grinding is meant some natural symptoms which are expressive of digestion, and prove that all things are right in the bodily frame, which a want of digestion would prove to the contrary. The voice of the Grinding is the natural appetite of the stomach to meat and drink, and is what we call hunger and thirst after food, with the strength and power of the stomach to retain what it receives, and nourishes the whole body. This Grinding and its voice takes in at once all the excellencies of nature, while they are in power; but, as age comes on, all the indicators of strength and concoction must be depraved, diminished, and abolished. Loss of appetite, with all its attendants, is the lowness of the voice of this Grinding; the doors of course are shut in the streets. When this is the case with a sickly, feeble, aged body, the mouth, the throat, in speaking, and the stomach in receiving food; the nostrils, and the eyes, which are called doors, these are all affected and must weaken as nature ceaseth to perform its original offices. Thus

these doors are shut in the street when the Grinding is low. The Streets are the several passages of the body, which the matter of nourishment passeth through, and are the roads and highways to and from the places where the Grinding is performed. May not this expression likewise refer to the inability of the sick, feeble, and aged, to encounter with the noise and bustle of business; and to the doors and shutters shut, as a signal of the departure of some of the family; and the voice of singing, even of common cheerfulness is altered.

Solomon gives us another intimation of the weakness of the human body—listlessness of repose, easily awakened. *He shall rise up at the voice of the Bird.* His age, or sickness, is like the wealth of the rich man, it will not suffer him to sleep; in the night he may have some unquiet drowsiness, but the approach of morn, when healthy young people sleep sound, he shall be broad awake, and at the crowing of the cock, or the singing of a Bird, he shall be rising up from his sleepless bed. Hence the saying, The singing of Birds and the sighing of old Men are generally contemporaries—these are as soon weary of their lodgings, through the pains and wakefulness in the night season, as the Birds are for lifting up their pleasant notes.

The last remark in this verse is, *The Daughters of Music shall be brought low.* These Daughters are considered by those skilled in Anatomy, to be both active and passive, such as make Music and such as receive Music; the active make a Music themselves, or bear a part in it; the other delights in that of which they have not the least share in making. There are three several kind of organs that do more immediately, yet distinctly and gradually, conduce to the production of vocal Music; the first is the Lungs, which are the proper instruments of our breathing; the second sort of organs that conduce to music, are such as form the Breath into the Voice, or Respiration, the Tongue, the Palate of the Mouth, the Teeth, especially the four Front Teeth, and, lastly, the Lips: these form the sound into a Voice; the others that modulate this Voice into Music, are the cartilaginous parts of the Wind-Pipe; the head of the Wind-Pipe is very small, yet it has thirteen Muscles belonging to it, most of which are framed only for the modulation of the Voice. Some shut the Pipe, some open it, some dilate, some contract it, so that acting severally or jointly, according as there is occasion, they do wonderfully conduce to the variation of sound. This also has got five Cartilages some are moveable, some immoveable, some of one form, others

of anther, that they may better contain the air and break the Voice into Melody. This is the Pipe to sing the high praises of God with, and which infinitely excels all the Instruments of Music: these are the active Daughters of Music which are brought low through age; the passive Daughters of Music are the organs of hearing; these are inward and outward; the outward Ear is spread abroad like a net, that it may gather and catch the sound as it rolls about the ocean of the air; the inward ear is a great secret, that no one can possibly understand—all have confessed their ignorance of this great matter; the first part we meet with is a thin strong membrane, which being placed over the Hole of the Ear, transversely, divides between the inward and the outward Ear; within this there are three Cavities, and three little Bones. So likewise there is implanted in the Ear a pure, subtil, and quiet air, with the filaments of the auditory Nerve; and then the whole Nerve itself. By the help of those several parts our hearing is thus performed; in age the several holes and Cavities of the Ears are stopped; the drum is unbraced; the hammer is weakened, the anvil is worn, the stirrup is broken, and the inward air is mixed and defiled; the filaments are dulled, the nerve itself is obstructed, so that there cannot but follow heaviness of hearing. Hence old *Barzillai* complains to David, 2 Samuel, xix, 35, *I am this day eighty years old, and can I discern between good and evil? Can I hear any more the voice of singing men and singing women? Wherefore should thy servant be yet a burden to my lord the king?* Thus the habit and taste for Music is brought low. This appears to be the literal sense of this passage, and some of those unpleasant days which many of our fallen race see with grief; all must lament it as creatures, but yet Believers must rejoice, as new creature, that all their musical days are not at an end—no, but that they are only beginning, as soon as they enter upon their Father's house above, and in the resurrection morn their harps, their powers, will be sweetly tuned to the praise of electing grace and eternal love. Permit me here to insert those lines from the hymn just quoted.

Lord I believe thou hast prepar'd,
Unworthy tho' I be,
For me a Blood-bought, free reward,
A golden harp for me.
'Tis tun'd and strung for endless years,
And form'd by power divine,

To sound in God the Father's ears,
No other name but thine.

In once more looking over this verse, my mind is impressed with other ideas, which I must commit to paper and send to my dear friend. We read in sacred Writ of the Door of the Heart, and of the Door of the Lips, and of the Conscience: these Doors are all opened by the finger of God. The conscience is quickened to feel the native guilt of our sins; the heart, the mind, all the faculties of the soul are opened by the operations of the eternal Spirit; the Understanding is enlightened to perceive the glories of the Saviour; the Will is bowed down to chuse Jesus, the Affections are set upon him, the Thoughts love to retain him; thus the Door of the Heart is open. Hence the Spouse says, *He put in his finger by the hole of the Door, and my bowels were moved for him, I rose up to open to my beloved.* The Door, here, may signify Faith in her heart; the Hole of the Door, a principle of love, though not wide open, free, and at sweet liberty, yet, as a principle, it was there. The Lord Jesus putting forth his powerful grace in the heart afresh, stirred her up, opened all the faculties, and afresh quickened the Conscience, she was led forth in soul after him. This is opening the Door. Hence he addresses the Laodicean Church; *Behold I stand at the door and knock; if any man hear my voice and open the door I will come into him.* This text has been awfully perverted by the Arminians and Modern Calvinists of the day: they tell us that the Deity is knocking at the door of every man's heart, begging to come in—waiting till the creature will open the door, and receive salvation! Alas! what a most miserable perversion of the text. The passage has nothing to do with the World, it is an address to the Church in a backsliding state, as the 5 Chapter of Songs shews. The Church knew her Beloved's voice, which is the Gospel. Every enlightened, quickened soul, understands the truth, whether it is drowsy or not; the soul is again made willing to receive Jesus, to seek most ardently the best of friends: this is opening the door, as we are made willing in the day, the time, the moment he puts forth his power. This is what the Church means by *the Beloved putting forth his hand by the Hole of the Door.* The heart moved after him, the door of the lips is opened, in prayer, in entreaty, and when admittance is gained, they are opened in praise, and in speaking good of his name. *They shall speak of the glory of thy kingdom.* Thus the doors are opened for the King of Glory to come in. These are everlasting doors and

will never be fully shut against Christ, nor will his doors ever be shut against his Church. He manifests himself to us, and we entertain him with the fruits of his own Spirit. The Grinders cease in the best of senses. The worst oppressors we ever meet with is a broken Law and a tempting Devil, and accusing conscience, this is the trouble of the Spirit. Hence that fine passage, *They shall cry to the Lord because of the oppressors. He shall send them a Saviour, a great one, and he shall deliver them.* The manifestation of pardon eases the conscience; the testimony of the Spirit that we are complete in Christ's righteousness, silences the Law, and the Saviour's great Work, pleaded by himself as an Advocate with the Father, drives off the Devil. Thus these oppressors cease, because they are few. A Believer can bear and endure any thing while all is right within, between God and the soul; not that he is rid of the inbeing of his sins, or the temptation of Satan, these will often oppress him; nor will they fully cease till he lays down his poor body in the grave.

Another sweet priviledge, *He shall rise up at the voice of the Bird.* This is a most blessed truth in our experience, for the gospel attended with power stirs up all our faculties, and we follow hard after God. This voice as used by the ministers of the word, is called *The time of the singing of Birds.* The Gospel Dispensation is called a spring time, and when the love of Jesus is felt casting out fear, when the storms of sin cease, by the voice of pardoning mercy, this sweet text is well understood: *My beloved spake, and said unto me, rise up my fair one, and come away, for lo, the winter is past, the rain is over and gone; the time of the singing of Birds is come.* The Lord Jesus, and the blessed Spirit of all Grace, are called Birds, and their voice is heard, known, and felt. *My Sheep hear my voice, and follow me.* These leave all when Jesus speaks by the Spirit to their souls; while every kind promise, every sweet invitation, and every precious declaration, form the sweet voice of Jesus, in the word and in the souls of them that believe. The Ministers of the Gospel are called Birds, and when they are understood and the power of their message is felt, the soul yields the obedience of faith. Conscience, approving and taking part with the man, as his experience is genuine, is a Bird, and is called by Solomon, *a Bird of the air*; this accuses or approves as God the Spirit influences it.

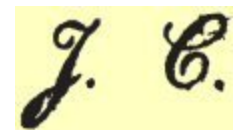
Thus, in the best of senses, we read this text; but, alas! we must take another view of it, as alluding to some evil days the soul may experience in

passing through this valley of Bochim, or Weeping. We find the saints of old at times had the Doors of their Hearts and Lips shut as well as open.—One said, *I am shut up, I cannot come forth.*—Another, *I go bound in the Spirit*: Another, *I was dumb, and opened not my mouth.* Ezekiel was dumb for seven days before the people, as a Preacher, and in the streets of Zion, that is among the inhabitants of Gospel Zion. This has been often experienced to their grief, shut up in prayer, either reluctantly going to the exercise, or else finding but little access there; hurrying through the act. Hence the charge against one of old, *Thou restrainest prayer before God.* Job did not say such did not pray, but they were not open, free, familiar, or staid at the throne till liberty was felt; but the act was performed merely to quiet conscience. At times in company, dumb almost about the things; and though the voice, the lips, the tongue, the lungs, were sweetly exercised before, *yet these Daughters of Music are brought low*, for they neither sound with prayer or praise, or godly conversation, or reproof, or comfort, to any other! Thus these Doors are shut in the streets. Conscience is, however still awake, and the poor Believer is alarmed; is startled at the voice of that Bird, when listening to its accusation of sin committed, of duty neglected, of a worldly spirit of levity or covetousness, or of some corruption given way to, or permitted to lie on the conscience. Thus the voice of the Bird is heard, and it is well to listen to it, lest another day it should fill the soul with horror and sorrow. This is what David felt after a long series of months, with guilt on his conscience, till Nathan came with his Parable; but not knowing what it meant, he vows vengeance against the man that did it, *That he should surely die.* This was indeed true, for it was David's wayfaring man, the man of sin, that came to steal the ewe Lamb; but David rose up at the voice of this Bird, and life went with the word to David's soul, *Thou art the man.* He felt it, conscience was afresh awakened, and it is our mercy to have the life of God in the Conscience; for the main difference between the Christian and the mere nominal Professor, lays in this; the one has got all his religion in his Head, and if that was cut off, he would have none; the others lays in his Conscience, as pardoned by blood, and quickened by the Holy Spirit.

Another evil day we may find in this dark state, when so sadly shut up, is the fewness of them that preach all the truth as it is in Jesus: Hence the Church in her sad state ran to some who did not know her case; of course

we find they ceased to give advice. She ran to others; they only rebuked her, and added affliction to her bonds, doubted her interest in the garments of Salvation. Hence she says, *The watchmen found me; to whom I said, Saw ye him whom my soul loveth?* Then again in the 5th Chapter, *The watchmen met me, they wounded me; they smote me; they took away my veil from me:* and sure I am that nothing can be more trying than for a soul in such intricate paths not to be able to find one to suit its case; and if they do, the word not being attended with power, they get neither light nor life. These are called Teeth in scripture, as they prepare food, break the bread of life, make all things plain, easy, and intelligible to the people; fixed in their Covenant Head, harmonize and agree in sentiment, at least in the main points, and engaged in the same work. These may cease by death—*the Prophets, do they live for ever?*—by removals in providence far from the abode of such a soul as I have been describing; or they may not be blest much to tried souls. They may be few in number, and those cease, as it respects their usefulness to some; so that, though they were once *as a lovely song, and as one who could play well on an instrument*, yet they may get dry, barren, and lifeless; at least, apparently so for any use they may be to a soul in the above circumstances. They make us mourn, nor can the Daughters of Music make melody again till he shines. We are compared Instruments of Music, set in tune by the Spirit, but can make no Music till he touches the chords of the heart; then upon the instruments of ten strings, he gets praise. The Doors of his Heart, his House, his Table, and his Throne, will never shut against you, any of his children. The days of your Mourning will soon end, the voice of Jesus will call you at the glorious resurrection of the just, when you will rise up at that voice, and sigh and sin no more.—*Hallelujah.*

Ever your's,



LETTER X.

TO MRS. D—.

Peckham, August 30, 1814.

MY DEAR FRIEND,

I once more resume my pen to give you a few more thoughts on the 12th of Ecclesiastes, but lament the limits, of a Letter, or even a Sermon would be too short to do justice to that subject. The Wise Man has in the verses we have already considered, described age to us, in the influence it has upon all the functions and faculties of a man; and shews how they are all weakened in his declining state. He now proceeds to notice one sad effect of age, that is, *Fear*. Verse 5, *Also they shall be afraid of that which is high, and fears shall be in the way; and the Almond tree shall flourish, and desire shall fail, and the Grasshopper shall be a burden, because man goeth to his long home, and the mourners go about the streets.*

The first is *Fear*, either of things high or low. *He shall be afraid of that which is high*, either in respect of place or objects; as steep, and eminent ways, hills, mountains, steeples, and towers; some of which formerly they could ascend without fear, in their juvenile and manly days; but it is not so now, they are weak in mind, nervous, low, timid, and fearful; so they are afraid of high things, as fiery meteors, strange apparitions, thunder, lightning, and such like. So they are likewise, probably, afraid of abstruse and mysterious points in any science, which while strong, they durst have ventured upon, but now they are too weak in the faculties to dive deep into them; they are always in fear lest tiles of houses, or chimney pots, or any thing else should fall on them, especially in windy weather. They have fears about them constantly on all hands; they see danger, lest they should dash their foot against a stone; lest some people in their hurry should push them down, or should rush upon them, and injure them. Being conscious of

their own impotency, it makes them most obnoxious to this terrible passion, which is the great change made on them in the time of age. Thus Solomon notices the change made in the mind by sickness, trouble, and age. He then points it out clearly upon the body in the next line, *The Almond tree shall flourish*. The learned tell us, this tree waketh, and riseth from its winter's repose before any other, it flowers in the month of January, and by March bringeth its fruit to maturity. The forwardness of this fruit-bearing tree is intimated by the vision which Jeremiah had of the speedy Destruction of Jerusalem; *For the word of the Lord came to Jeremiah, saying, what seest thou? And he said, I see a rod of an Almond tree. Then said the Lord, thou hast well seen, I will hasten my word to fulfil it. Jeremiah, 1 chapter, xi verse*. This was to shew the speedy fulfilling of the word of God against that City. Now there is no change that befalleth man, that can be so lively represented by the blooming of the Almond tree, as that whereby the hair of the head becomes hoary and white. The grey head is similar to this tree, for its whiteness, so in hastiness of appearance, as the Almond tree buds sooner by two or three months than most other trees, so do these hasty buds of age appear; these steal upon men suddenly before they are aware. Some peoples' hair turns grey at thirty or forty years of age, while other symptoms of the decay of life do not appear on them till sixty or seventy years of age. Both these attract attention. An Almond tree in full blossom, and an almond head, especially if found in the ways of God, these are alike in their indications, they foretel what is approaching—a change; fruit will come after; so grey hairs prognosticate that death is at hand; these are Church-yard flowers, which serve, like passing bells, to give those notice that bear them, that their end is near. Two things more the Wise Man observes; *The Grasshopper shall be a burden, and desire shall fail*. The learned say the word *Grasshopper*, likewise signifies the Locust, and will apply to both in the original language; and they likewise suppose that Solomon here alludes to some parts of the body, which being shrivelled and deformed, appear like the Locust and Grasshopper. These Species are both of them hard, crusty, cragged, crumpling creatures, differing from all others, principally in the protuberance of the limbs, having their legs strangely crooked, and their joints very closely inverted, and at a great distance from the trunk of their body. This description may refer to some of the bones in the neck, the back, the loins, the heels, and the ancles. Now when a man by reason of age, begins to stoop, and bend forwards, and withal those fleshy parts that cover

these processes, begin to shrink and decay, he resembles these creatures. This may also include the change upon the cartilages of the body, the Ligaments, the Membranes, the Fibres, the Veins, the Nerves, the Arteries, the Tendons, and the like, which all grow harder and drier in old age, and become a burden; the skin, likewise, as man declines, becomes crusty, dry, callous, and consequently falls into many wrinkles. This may also include that fretfulness to which aged people are subject; every thing is a burden, though light, weak or trifling as a Grasshopper. Good Mr. Henry, observes, Perhaps this Grasshopper or Locust was some light food, such as John did eat; but even this was a burden to an aged man's stomach; then, of course, through these things Solomon well adds, *Desire shall fail*: Sensual and natural desire for food, pleasure, or any sensual delight whatever. This word *Desire*, the celebrated Dr. Smith says, should be translated *Capers*, the fruit, or rather the flowers of the Caper Shrub, or Bush; and alludes to something calculated to give appetite; and that as the Grasshopper did represent the Bones, or hard parts of the Body, so these the soft, spongy, and dilated; and what Solomon by this expression means, is the alteration of all the moist and tender parts of the body, usually called the Sanguineous; including the change that befalls the Blood, and the natural Humours of the Body in time of age, for they become low, and much depauperated; they are diminished and far less in quality than they were before. The reason of this is, *for man goeth to his long home, and the mourners go about the streets*. The grave, said Job, is my house, and soon the funeral proclamation must be repeated over us, *Dust thou art, and unto dust shall thou return*. The grave is the home for the body, when once it comes there, as long as there is any dust to cover it, or heavens to surround it, Man lieth down, and riseth not till the Heavens be no more; they shall not awake, nor be raised out of their sleep till death is swallowed up in victory. *And the mourners go about the streets*. This we see daily; the friends, the relations, characters of every description. Mourning, is not because my friend is gone to glory, but on account of the loss I sustain, that person being near and dear to me; besides, it is a solemn call, *Be ye also ready, for in such an hour as ye think not, the Son of Man cometh*. And oh, my dear friend, to have the lamp of salvation from sin, its guilt, and curse, and power, and to have my soul filled with joy in God, through Jesus—this is the oil which will blaze when he appeareth. But if I have not much joy, I am blessed with a good hope, through grace; a hope that maketh not ashamed, and God declares it shall never be lost;

There is hope in thy end, and thy expectation shall not be cut off. Praise ye the Lord.

I would again glance at this Text in another sense. Having considered the evil days coming on the body in this verse, let us once more survey some days of evil, in which I am sure you and I can say I have no pleasure in them. *Fear shall be in the way, and the Almond tree shall flourish; the Grasshopper be a burden, and desire shall fail, for man goeth to his long home, and the mourners go about the streets.* Without turning, twisting, or wresting this Text, I am forcibly struck with the following thoughts, which I must pen and send you. 1st. The Believer's home. 2ndly. The way to it. 3rdly. The fears which attend him. 4thly. Their cause, which is a source of grief, and causes the spiritual mourners to go about the streets of Zion. I know of no dwelling or resting place, for a soul born of God, but the everlasting love of God in Covenant; the Person and Work of the Lord Jesus Christ. This is my habitation, my dwelling, my resting place; nor is there any safety, happiness, felicity, or peace, any where else. All that are born of God, naturally, in this sense, tend to this one grand object. Hence the question of a seeking soul, Does God love me? Did Jesus die for me?—and after the soul knows this, yet in general, there is a thirsting after greater knowledge, and greater enjoyment of it, nor is a Believer ever at home but when he is here. He rests not in his attainments of this knowledge, but is anxious to go on to know the Lord, in his infinite love; to feel more, to enjoy more, to be delighted with more of it, till he arrives at perfect bliss, and is filled with all the fulness of God, which is love. He tastes what the poet did, and has exprest in these two lines:

'Tis heaven to rest in thine embrace,
And no where else but there.

This is our resting place, as Faith apprehends it in its antiquity, its freeness, power, complacency, and beneficence: It is truly delightful to eye the goings forth of this Love, in the ancient settlements, in the covenant engagements of each Person in the adorable Trinity, in the gift of Jesus to the Church, in his great work, and wonderful Person, as God-Man Mediator, in the Gifts of the Spirit, and all his saving operations upon the soul, testifying of Christ, as putting away sin, as obeying the Law, as delivering us from going down into the pit, and making intercession for us. On these topics we, who have

the Life and love of God, are quite at home; especially as the Holy Ghost realizes them in our hearts; for this we labour in Spirit, to know and enjoy; and this one point we wish to die to know, and to plunge in this sea of bliss. —To view the Father's love, the Son's dear face, and the Holy Spirit's Grace, in Heaven, are objects worth dying for; this is the home, the place, the state, the mansions of peace, rest, joy, satisfaction, and pleasure, we hope to get to shortly. This is our long home, eternal as the throne of God. No foe shall ever enter there. No friend shall ever depart—they shall go no more out; so shall we be ever with the Lord. This is our everlasting home, nor will our Lord let us rest short of this. There may we meet soon, Amen.

But do you ask me, 2ndly. The way? It is clearly set forth in the word, and I hope you have long known it, and highly approved of it, and been led into it; nor shall you ever finally depart from it. The word of truth says, I am *the* way; not *a* way, but *the* way. Ah, my dear Friend, how lamentable that thousands are deluding their souls with this unscriptural notion, that all the sects, parties, and religious denominations in the world, are only as so many different ways to one city. Hence they suppose the Turk, the Pagan, the Papist, the Socinian, the Arian, the Arminian, and the Antinomian, are all going right, and some out of all these will be saved as such. Alas, what an error; there never was but one way to God, to heaven, and to glory, and that is Christ, as the adorable Mediator; all that reject this will find to their grief, that *whatever* way they went it led to the chambers of death; it led to hell. What a mercy to be satisfied with a precious Saviour, and to hear the voice of the Word and Spirit pointing to him, saying, *This is the way, walk ye in it*. Christ is the way to the Father, to the knowledge and enjoyment of his love. By the sacrifice he offered, by his perfect law-fulfilling Righteousness, by the path he trod as our fore-runner, by the Door of Hope that he opened, by the way of life he cast up, and consecrated through the vail of his flesh, by the doctrine he taught, by the example he set, and by the promise of life and peace. We are brought into this way by the Holy Spirit of Promise, and kept in it by the same, with an eye to Jesus, as the way. We walk in his appointments, in his ordinances. We use them to gain the knowledge of the Pearl of great price. By waiting upon him we renew our strength, and by abiding in him we bring forth fruit. This way leads us to God, and will bring us to glory, assure as it brings us to a sense of his love on earth. Many have waited long, and travelled far in this way, before they

have been very fully persuaded of God's Love to them; but all shall have their minds satisfied about that, though not all in the same degree, as walking in this way of truth, way of holiness, way of wisdom, way of charity, way of life, and way of peace. We are called Strangers, Pilgrims, Travellers, Runners in a Race, and going a Journey. Our Pilgrim's Coat is an imputed righteousness; our Staff is Christ; our Map is his word; the Girdle is truth; our Shoes is peace; our Way is marked out for us, omnipotent Power guards us, infinite Wisdom directs us, Mercy is often shewed us, and eternal Love cheers us, while we can sing with a Pilgrim who has reached glory before us,

How harsh soe'er the way,
Dear Saviour still lead on.

But as this is God's way we must expect to meet with enemies, with savage beasts of prey, with robbers, many a stormy day, and many a dismal night, when neither moon nor stars appear to cheer the Pilgrim's way, for it is our lot to travel much by night; this begets fears lest we have come wrong, lest this be not the right road. God's dear people are unavoidably the subject of many fears; when the eyes are first opened, they fear the wrath of God, they fear Death, Judgment, and Eternity: these are high things. If they hear of Christ, the Promises, and Ordinances, they fear to come to these high things, or make use of them, lest they should presume. Thus there are fears in the way, and many times after God has raised the soul up to hope, they fear the work is not genuine; they fear they shall fall into sin, and disgrace their profession; and feeling the power of sin, and the weakness of their souls, they fear they shall at last fall away. When they see many apparently brighter characters than themselves go back into the world, or sink into error, they fear it will one day be their case; and when they see how far a person may go in a profession and yet be nothing, they startle, they fear, lest they should. Thus we find fears in the way, and when the mind is low, deprest, and every grace of the spirit, to all human appearance out of exercise, they are afraid of high, great, precious, and important Doctrines, lest they should presume in meddling with them, fearing they have no interest in them. Sometimes fears of poverty, pain, persecution, and what we may suffer in the agonies of death. These kind of fears may come on us, and above all, the fears that all we have experienced may be a delusion, and

that hypocrites may come as far as we have, talk better than we do, and give a better account of themselves than we can; this makes us fear in the way. All these fears is for want of looking unto Jesus, and permitting Satan to get so much ground, by listening to his suggestions. These fears, likewise, are occasioned by other feelings, and trying parts of our experience. What Satan principally aims at is to make us as miserable as himself, and as rebellious against God; to this end he endeavours to get us to look within in seasons of darkness, that we may dispute the whole of the Spirit's work, and consider all our sins, failings, and corruptions as sure tokens of a speedy destruction, just as Jeremiah saw the rod of an Almond tree speedily flourishing; so might have been our profession, but soon gone away. So we fear may be all our religion, and then be damned for being hypocrites. O the misery of looking within, when we should be looking unto Jesus! What a gloomy prospect before us! what unbelieving fears are indulged; and this must be our misery, till the Saviour shines again. But what a mercy when we have grace enough to look from our sins, our grace, our Religion, or any thing in us, or done by us, to God the Father's Christ, who lived and died for poor sinners.

A second source of fears is, Sin but little felt, so as to be lamented, so as to break the heart, humble the spirit, and endear the Saviour. It appears God sometimes sent the Grasshoppers to devour the fruits of the earth, as in Amos, chapter 7, where the Prophet foresees the Destruction of Jerusalem, by Pul, king of Assyria, bringing his vast troop to devour that land, coming up like Grasshoppers for their number and destructive influence. So in the Book of Judges it is said, the enemies came up among them as Grasshoppers for multitude to destroy them. As these represented the enemies of God's dear people of old, do they not point out the corruptions of the heart, inbred sin, the Old man, with its deceitful lusts? Are they not numerous as Grasshoppers, and as destructive to every thing that is good? Do not these destroy our peace, our joy, our bright evidences, and cause us, sometimes, to fear we have neither part nor lot in the matter, especially when we cannot see that these sins are pardoned by the precious blood of Christ?—These are felt as a burden too heavy to bear, and a burden we fear will sink us to hell, till we believe they are all blotted out, then the inbeing of them becomes a burden to us. But here we must admire divine mercy, communicating to us spiritual life that we may feel these things a burden.

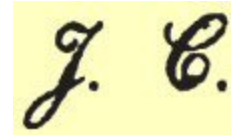
As this life operates the difference between a child of God and one that is not, is clearly seen; they who are not quickened by the Spirit do not feel these things; but, alas, my dear Friend, have not you been left in such a strange state of mind, that you have neither felt sin, nor grace, neither mourned at the judgments of God, the terrors of hell, the sufferings of Christ, the afflictions of the Church, nor the plague of the heart. O! worst of states my soul ever was in; this deadness, carelessness, dull, stupid, heavy frame, I hate it, I lament it. Before this came on I could sigh deeply on account of my sins, their number, and destructive tendency, but now I have fresh fears that all is not right, because I don't see sin such an evil as it is. I don't groan beneath it; I don't lament my vileness. Surely my soul cannot be right with God, while this is the case; the Grasshopper is a burden, because it is so light; I am burdened, because I don't feel sin that heavy, hateful burden, I have felt it, and as others do.—Thus you see, my dear sister, what poor, foolish, fearful creatures we are, how discontented with the cross; when we feel much sin, we fear, and when we scarcely feel it at all, then we fear also. Alas, how much of poor Jonah's spirit do we all possess. Murmuring, repining, rebelling.

But I must mention a third source of *Fear, The failing of Desires*. The people of God are the objects of his desire; Christ saw them in the glass of the Father's decrees and purposes. He desired them. Hence the Church triumphs in the Song, *I am my Beloved's and his desire is towards me*. He desired the Church for himself, and gained it, every one that he desired, in electing grace, is brought to desire Christ, by calling grace, and one blessed effect of being truly called, is the desire of the soul towards God, to hold communion with him, to be like him, and to be with him. Hence that sweet Promise will one day be accomplished, *He will fulfil the desire of them that fear him*. This will not be till we awake up in his likeness; then, but not till then, shall we be satisfied.

These desires of the soul are highly commended by the Saviour, as they spring from a feeling sense of need; are the pulse of the soul, which beats for God. Many a poor Believer in seasons of darkness, has blessed God for the feeling desire, the hunger, the thirst, the wish for what God has promised, and what the soul feels its need of. But let me ask you again, have you not found such days of evil, as the loss of these desires? No life, no spirituality, no appetite, no earnestness, no fervent desires, not a breath

of the New man felt or seen; and to be left in this state a considerable time, when all has been shut up? I have still triumphed in my desires, but when *these* have failed, all is dark, gloomy, wretched, desolate. This has sent me mourning about the streets of Zion, crying, *Saw ye him whom my soul loveth?* This is the enquiry of souls who are afresh quickened to feel their native guilt, their deadness, and want of the light of comfort, of joy, of peace, and the testimony of the Holy Spirit. The Saviour was sent to comfort them that mourn after a godly sort, sorrowing after Jesus; to gain a sense of his love, a token for good, a fresh view of pardon, and eternal life. This is calculated to comfort the mourner in Zion, to cheer his heart, and enable him to look forward to death and the grave, with sweet composure, knowing Jesus is the conqueror of death, spiritual, temporal, and eternal. To him, I commend you, and remain

Your's in him,

A handwritten signature in black ink on a yellow rectangular background. The signature consists of the letters 'J.' followed by 'C.' in a cursive, calligraphic style.

LETTER XI.

TO MRS. D—.

Peckham, September 30, 1814.

MY DEAR FRIEND IN CHRIST JESUS.

I have been just reflecting a little on that glorious Title and Office of our most blessed Lord, a *Surety*: the longer I live the more I feel the need of him as such; the bondage, sin, and misery I am daily and hourly experiencing, except a few sweet seasons of liberty in prayer, preaching, writing, and conversing about the precious things of God. It is well he became one with us, in the eye of the law, that he kindly undertook for us, and infallibly secured the payment of that obedience it demanded of us. This whole debt he took upon himself, and crossed our name from the bond, and addressed his divine Father for us, *Whatsoever my people owe thee, put that to my account*. The Father graciously accepted this, and has declared himself well pleased with it. Every blessed view of this gives me hope, peace, and rest. I am truly miserable but when this is shewed me, then I feel a sweet serenity of mind. O! precious Surety, O! glorious Redeemer, thy Person, thy Name, and thy Work, is very dear to my heart:

No other stay have I beside,
If these should alter I must fall.

I need this to support me now, I shall need it as much when my heart and flesh fail. *When the Silver Cord is loosed, when the Golden Bowl is broken at the Cistern, when the Pitcher is broken at the Fountain, and the Wheel broken at the Cistern*, this glorious Saviour will then carry my regenerated spirit to God who gave it me, and this is as sure to my soul as that God has begun the good Work in it. He begins it with a view to carry it on, and he will perfect that which concerneth me, for his mercy endureth for ever.

I will now drop you a few thoughts on the sixth verse, with which I must close these letters, which I trust you will candidly read, and where I err, attribute that to me, but receive the truth as from that God whose I am, and whom I serve. Here are four symptoms of approaching dissolution; the first is *the loosing the Silver Cord*. By this is most probably meant the Spinal Marrow, and all the Nerves arising therefrom; with all the Filaments, Fibres, and Tendons that proceed from those Nerves; as there can be no motion or drawing performed in all the Body without these; and through the influence of the animal Spirits upon them; and although these belong to the spinal Marrow, and all draw together as it were, yet Solomon expresses it in one word, *the Silver Cord*, because the rest are but a continuation of the same thing. This is called the Silver Cord from its colour, for it appears to the eye a white, bright as silver; it is seated deep in the body; it lays lower and deeper, and safer than the Veins or Arteries, or other common conveyers in the Body, and it is reckoned the most excellent of all, so that some Philosophers have termed it the Foundation of Life. The loosing of this Cord, is an undoubted sign of death; sometimes this is only affected in one part, and is the cause of Paralytics, but when it happens to the head of the spinal Marrow, it hinders the influence of the spirits upon the whole Silver Cord, and consequently takes away all sense and motion from all the subjected parts, and gives a sure prognostic of death, especially in aged people. Thus the Silver Cord is loosed.

The next object worthy notice is, *the Golden Bowl broken*, by which some think is meant the Scull pan; or, as the Seventy translate it, the Repository of the Brain. The celebrated Dr. *Smith* (to whom I am indebted for many of his ideas on Anatomy) says, there are two Membranes within the Skull, a thicker and harder, and a thinner and finer, which does more immediately encompass the Brain, and by an immediate contact, encircles the very Substance of it, which seems to me to be the Golden Bowl, so called, by way of eminence, which is broken. This is called Golden, for the same reason that the other is called the Silver Cord, in its colour. The Membrane is of a flavious colour, nearer to that of Gold; it is hidden, secret, and well defended; and requires much wisdom and time to find out all its secret caverns and mysterious branches, and also for its ductility; above all, it may be compared to Gold, for excellency and use. Now as long as man remains in his strength, this Golden Bowl is knit unto itself in all its parts, but in the

event of extreme old age, when he is just giving up the ghost, it can no longer retain itself, by reason of its natural dryness, shrivelling into itself, or preternatural moisture, imbibing excrementitious humours, till it is over full, it often snaps asunder, and so recurs into itself, from whence the Brain must naturally subside, and all the parts cease from their several uses; upon this we perceive a change of the whole countenance; the nose appears very sharp, the eyes sunk into the head, the temples are pinched in, with all the other symptoms of approaching dissolution. This brings the house down indeed, when the animal faculty is so deeply affected. I think there is something very interesting in the idea of the body compared to a *Golden Bowl*, not China, Earthenware, or Tin, but *Gold*, to shew how precious our bodies are in his sight who redeemed them; that he will take special care of them, collect all the various pieces together, and raise them up a glorious body by and by.

The third point worthy our consideration, is, *The Pitcher broken at the Fountain*. This must refer to something belonging to the vital faculty; it appears in sacred Scriptures, that the life of man consists in his blood; *For the life of all Flesh is in the Blood thereof*; and this most noble liquor of Life, hath a primary Seat or Fountain, where it is principally made, and from whence it is dispensed through the whole Body, and this Fountain is the Heart, *for out of it are the issues of life*. This part continually issueth out abundance of Blood, wherein is the life, to all the parts of the body.— This is a deep Fountain, it is the Fountain of Life, the first living, and last dying Part of Man. Within the Body of the Heart there are two firmly-divided Cavities, a right and left, called Ventricles; from these are certain vessels. Out of the right Ventricle, of the Heart, proceeds the great Vein, which sends forth Branches throughout the whole, and hath, at its entrance into the Heart, certain Portals, and also an Artery. Out of the left Ventricle proceeds a Vein, inserted into the Lungs, and also the great Artery, which disperseth its Branches throughout the whole Body, both whose Cavities are defended with the like Portals. How the blood passeth in and through these passages I have not time to describe, I wish I had. By the Pitcher, therefore, we must understand the true and proper concepticle of the Blood, namely, the Veins, which throughout the whole body, serve only as vessels to contain that noble liquor, and carry it back again to the Fountain. This is the Pitcher here intended. The Fountain is the right Ventricle of the Heart.

But neither the Fountain nor Pitcher continues for ever; the Pitcher does not go so often to the Fountain but at last it comes home broken. The breaking of it in old age, is the failing of the Veins, their ceasing from their natural action and use; when they can no longer carry back, nor conveniently pass into the Heart that liquor, the blood they contain, it stops, it is stagnated, it dies in the Veins. This is *breaking the Pitcher at the Fountain*.

Finally, *The Wheel broken at the Cistern*. The Cistern is the left Ventricle of the Heart, as the Fountain is represented as the right; for the Blood being enlivened and ennobled in the right Ventricle, it remains only to be dispersed into these several parts it is to quicken, which it cannot consequently do, except it be received into this Cistern. The Wheel is that round, or circulation of the Blood which flows from the left Ventricle of the Heart. Take this part of the symptom of Death, the chasing of the Pulse; the instruments of pulsation decay, and can no longer perform that work which must necessarily be continued for the preservation of life; when that ceases to beat, the man ceaseth to live; thus the Wheel, which till now, run its constant round, is broken at the Cistern, heart and flesh now fail. O! that when this is your case and mine, we may have nothing to do but to depart and be with Christ. May our Spirits return to God who gave them, while the poor tabernacle returns to its original dust. Solemn thought!—But the Gospel opens to my wondering, pleasing view, the Resurrection of this Body, formed and fashioned like the glorious Body of my Jesus, who appeared on Mount Tabor, or Mount Lebanon, as perhaps we shall appear when he comes in glory. May this be your felicity and mine, *Amen*.

Do accept a few thoughts more upon this verse, of the evil days which may come on the mystical Body of Christ, which is drawn together, acts, moves, and is kept together by the strong Silver Cord of everlasting love. *I drew them with the Cords of Love, with loving kindness have I drawn thee*.—This keeps the whole Body together; and Paul tells us to *endeavour to keep the unity of the Spirit in the bond of peace*. Love is the bond; *put on charity, which is the bond of perfectness*. This is the Cord that draws us to heaven: this unites us in heart to Jesus. Love as a principle, and as shed abroad in the heart, unites us to his Truth, his Ways, his Ministers and his People. When this is sweetly felt, and especially in that degree the Apostle speaks of, when perfect, that is eternal love comes in, it casts out fear, which hath torment: to live under this influence is truly blessed, but such seasons are

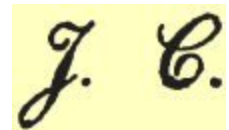
short, they are pleasant days truly; and in our first setting out, or some part of our pilgrimage, we do experience them truly blessed. So did Solomon, but he had some evil days, when his own corrupt heart overflowed with sin, which brought on a sad distance between God and his soul. This is also attended with a shyness to the Household of Faith, and very few pleasant seasons in God's House of Prayer. No love is felt to Jesus, and scarce a desire after him; very little affection is felt to faithful ministers, as there is but little received under their message, which used to be so sweet to them, and their love to ministers so strong, for the truth's sake. Thus, by contracted guilt, the cord of love is loosed, not in God, but in our exercise of this grace. So of those we once viewed saints, many we have proved to be nothing but hypocrites; some only mumping a living under the mask of religion; some lying in wait to deceive; some watching for our halting, to find something amiss in our conduct; and if they can catch any thing, it is marrow and fatness to their bones. Tattling, lying, backbiting, jealousies, and evil speaking. These things we begin to discover, and groan on account of them in Professors, till we can hardly help exclaiming with the Prophet, *There is none upright among men, the best of them is a briar, the most upright is sharper than a thorn hedge.* Very little spiritual love being now felt, the Silver Cord, appears to be loosed, not that the principle is lost, but God is teaching the Believer wisdom, and directing the principle of love to the proper object, even to the Household of Faith—not to every Professor, but only to those who stand manifest in our consciences, that they are taught of God; yet it must be acknowledged that while the heart is shut up from the exercise of love it is an evil, a trying day. Sin on the conscience, backsliding, getting into a worldly spirit, the affections being entangled with creature love—these things bring on evil days. O! what a mercy to have the heart right with God. When the soul is thus filled with love, it is always attended with an illuminated mind, a mind receiving the truth. Charity rejoiceth in the truth, believeth all things God hath said, as well as hopeth for what God hath promised. But it is possible to stumble upon the dark mountains; God may cause darkness to come on the mind, the judgment to be bewildered, and errors to creep in—the Golden Bowl may be broken.—Ephraim, says God, is oppressed and broken in judgment, either by evil men, who lay in wait to deceive, or by a curious spirit, which a Believer may be plagued with, till he has imbibed some error, which leads him into darkness, bondage, and misery. A sound judgment is valuable, like

a Golden Bowl, but many of God's children have got proud, and God has permitted Satan to lay a snare for their feet, *a haughty Spirit before a fall*, and into awful errors they have run, till days of trouble have come on, and they have found out their errors. Moreover, real contrition for sin; a heart affected with grief after the Saviour, mourning on account of him.—Compunction and godly sorrow of heart is precious, is valuable to God; with this sacrifice he is well pleased; this is a Golden Bowl broken indeed, in the best of senses. *Blessed are they that mourn, for they shall be comforted.* The Silver Cord of Love, the Golden Bowl of a sound Judgment, and an heart influenced by the Spirit of Grace, are in sweet connexion; these make a Believer shine in the Church—such are valuable characters, but they are few. *My soul desired the first ripe Fruit.*

The Pitcher may be broken at the Fountain. Our Lord Jesus is a never-failing Fountain in his Person, in his Offices, in his Love, and in his Work. He is the Fountain of all spiritual and eternal Life. What a deep, never-failing, abundant source of all good he is to his Covenant People. He is a fountain of Gardens for his Church, a Fountain of living Waters, and a Fountain opened for Sin and Uncleaness. Faith wrought in the heart, may be compared to a Pitcher, which draws its supplies from that inexhaustible source of all blessings. It receives the Atonement into the conscience, it is the great Artery in the spiritual Body, which conveys peace and joy through the whole soul, as it receives the precious Blood from the heart of Christ, and every other blessing is in this one, *Jesus died for me.* While Faith is thus busied, the exercises of Religion, like a wheel, go their happy round to the Cistern of Gospel Ordinances; for a while Faith is thus exercised on Jesus, the mind, the soul is made willing, and rolls its happy round, like a wheel well oiled. Faith is going to the Fountain while the Believer is willingly running the way of God's Commands. It is worthy our notice, that all the treasures of blessings in Christ, are compared to a Fountain; but in Ordinances, in Ministers, and Means, it is but a Cistern. Hence the folly of those who seek salvation in their round of duties; they forsake the Fountain, and cleave, in general, to those *Cisterns that can hold no water.* Faithful Ministers and Gospel Ordinances hold the Water of Life, and wisdom declares the man of understanding shall draw it out. This I dare say you can prove in your own experience; if your soul is, through faith in the Person and Work of Jesus, happy in his love—all the while the Pitcher of Faith is

bringing you such supplies, you can come as regular to the Cistern of Gospel Ordinances, and as willing as a wheel, well set in motion, goes its round. In such days of the Power of Faith, we are made willing to believe, to do, to suffer, and to obey. Such days we have had, but we have had some evil days besides, some opposite reasons, when the Pitcher of Faith appeared to be broken, for all the good it did for us; it ceased to act, at least in the way it had done; it brought no grace, no love, no joy, no comfort; it was like a Broken Pitcher; not that it can cease to exist, as a principle, but only in its motions, 'tis weak, low, and of course the mind must be low, and the wheel move slowly, if it moves at all, in Ordinances, in Conversation, in Prayer, in Reading, and every other religious Exercise. Ah, my dear friend, have you not met with such days of evil? *but all things work together for good*, even those sins, those hindrances to our comfort, shall terminate right; for *the elder sin shall serve the younger*. Sin makes us pray, cry, groan, wrestle, entreat; this makes Faith grow and increase, and what belongs to God ascends to him, gravitates to its own centre. Faith comes from him, is busied about him, affections go to him, hope centers in him, patience waits on him, humility is precious to him; this is the fruit of his own Spirit, and we find by daily experience, that the Spirit goes to God who gave it, while all that is carnal in us will cleave to the dust, to sin, to the world, to all that is opposite to God; like loves its like, *that which is born of the Spirit, is Spirit*, and delights in spiritual objects; *that which is born of the Flesh is Flesh*, and is desirous of sensual gratification. This is the Believer's affliction; but we shall soon be done with time, and commune upon an eternal scene, when all that belongs to the earth, to the dust, will return to it, and all of me, and belonging to me, will return to him from whom it came. The Lord carry on his Work in your soul and mine; and while we live, may we be enabled, through all, and by all our evil days, to distinguish between the Dust and the Spirit, the Old-Man and the New—to watch the operations of both; lament the one, and bless God for the other.

Yours in him,

A handwritten signature in black ink on a yellow rectangular background. The signature consists of the letters 'J.' followed by 'C.' in a cursive, slightly stylized font.

FINIS.

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